Statistical Mechanics Rediscovered through the Lens of the Entropy Maximization Principle

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Contents

I Statistical Derivation of Ensembles **4**

1 Entropy Maximization Principle **5**

1.1 Gibbs–Shannon Entropy 5

1.2 Entropy Maximization 6

2 The Microcanonical Ensemble **7**

3 The Canonical Ensemble **8**

3.1 First and Second Laws of Thermodynamics — Meaning of the Multipliers 10

3.2 Extensive and Intensive Variables 11

3.3 Energy Fluctuation, Thermodynamic Limit and Equivalence of Ensembles 12

3.4 Zeroth Law of Thermodynamics 13

4 Beyond Canonical Ensemble **15**

4.1 Internal Energy Minimization 15

4.2 Thermodynamic Potential 16

4.3 The Legendre Transformation 16

4.4 Multivariable Legendre Transformation 17

4.5 NVT Ensemble — Helmholtz Free Energy 18

4.6 NPS Ensemble — Enthalpy 19

5 The Grand Canonical Ensemble **21**

5.1 Particle Number Fluctuation, Thermodynamic Limit and Equivalence of Ensembles Revisited 23

5.2 μVT Ensemble — Grand Potential 23

5.3 NPT Ensemble — Gibbs Free Energy 24

5.4 Euler's Homogeneous Function Theorem 25

5.5 Multi-Component System 26

5.6 Mixing Entropy and the Gibbs Paradox 27

5.7 Gibbs–Duhem Relation 29

II Phase Transitions **31**

6 First-Order Phase Transitions and Phase Diagrams **32**

6.1 Gibbs Phase Rule 32

6.2 Clapeyron Equation and Fixed-Composition (P–T) Phase Diagram 33

6.3 Unary System 34

7 Binary System **39**

7.1 The X–P–T Diagram 39

7.2 Gibbs Free Energy of a Binary Solution 39

7.3 Chemical Potentials as Tangent Intercepts 40

7.4 Solution Models 40
7.5 Two-Phase Equilibrium: Common Tangent and Lever Rule 40
7.6 Isobaric T–X Diagram of an Isomorphous System 42
7.7 Isothermal P–X Diagram of a Liquid–Vapor System 43
7.8 The P–T Projection 44
7.9 Beyond the Ideal Solution: Miscibility Gap 44

III Classical Thermodynamics **47**

IV Physical Chemistry **47**

V Quantum Statistical Mechanics **47**

Part I

Statistical Derivation of Ensembles

1 Entropy Maximization Principle

The conventional approach and its limitation. The conventional introduction to statistical mechanics rests on four notions:

- A microstate is a complete description of every microscopic parameter of the system.
- In an isolated system, all microstates are equally likely.
- A macrostate is a group of microstates that share the same macroscopic observables.
- Macrostates that contain more microstates are observed more often, so the observed macrostate is the most probable one.

Boltzmann, Gibbs and other founders of thermodynamics developed this approach. The approach is physically intuitive. However, an explanation of why a system settles into the most probable macrostate requires ergodicity and dynamical arguments, which are difficult to make rigorous.

The MaxEnt alternative. This document follows Jaynes in treating equilibrium statistical mechanics as a constrained optimization problem, in which the entropy is maximized subject to what is known macroscopically about the system. This approach is called the Entropy Maximization Principle (MaxEnt).

1.1 Gibbs–Shannon Entropy

From "disorder" to ignorance. The meaning of entropy has long been debated. The popular description of entropy as "disorder" is not a definition, because the description gives no quantitative measure of disorder. Clausius, Boltzmann and other founders regarded entropy as a driving force of thermodynamic processes, which left open the question of which physical quantity entropy encodes. Jaynes instead argued that entropy is not a property of the body itself but a measure of the observer's ignorance about the body. The Gibbs–Shannon entropy formalizes this idea for Ω events that occur with probabilities $p(i)$:

$$\boxed{S(p) = -\sum_{i=1}^{\Omega} p(i) \ln p(i).} \tag{1.1}$$

Why the Gibbs–Shannon entropy measures ignorance. The term $-\ln p(i)$, called the surprisal of event i, measures the ignorance about that event:

- A certain event has $p(i) = 1$, so the surprisal is $-\ln 1 = 0$.
- A rare event has a small $p(i)$, so the surprisal is large.

A direct sum of $-\ln p(i)$ would fail, because knowing that an event will occur and knowing that the event will not occur both mean low ignorance. Each term is therefore weighted by $p(i)$. Rare events seldom occur, and near-certain events are already expected, so both contribute little to the total. Thus, S is the expected surprisal, $\langle -\ln p \rangle$.

1.2 Entropy Maximization

The principle of maximum ignorance. Jaynes' second idea is to choose the distribution that maximizes the ignorance, that is, the Gibbs–Shannon entropy $S(p)$, subject to the known constraints whenever the underlying mechanism is unknown. A lower-entropy distribution would introduce an unexplained bias toward some events. For example, the two outcomes of a coin flip should have equal probabilities unless a constraint, such as a loaded coin, states otherwise.

Formulating the constrained optimization. For simplicity, p_i replaces $p(i)$ from now on, because only one probability distribution appears. Each known constraint is written as $g_a(p) = 0$. For a constraint on the expectation value of an observable that takes the value $g_a(i)$ in event i,

$$g_a(p) = \sum_i p_i \, g_a(i) - \langle g_a \rangle .$$

Lagrange multipliers remove the constraints through the Lagrangian

$$\boxed{\mathcal{L}(p) = -\sum_i p_i \ln p_i - \alpha \left(\sum_i p_i - 1 \right) - \sum_a \lambda_a \, g_a(p),} \tag{1.2}$$

where α enforces normalization and each λ_a enforces one constraint. The maximizing distribution satisfies

$$\boxed{\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial p_i} = 0, \qquad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \alpha} = 0, \qquad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \lambda_a} = 0.} \tag{1.3}$$

The last two conditions reproduce normalization and the constraints. The first condition determines p_i.

The general MaxEnt distribution. For expectation-value constraints, $\partial g_a / \partial p_i = g_a(i)$. The first condition in Eq. (1.3) then gives

$$-\ln p_i - 1 - \alpha - \sum_a \lambda_a \, g_a(i) = 0,$$

$$p_i = e^{-1-\alpha} \exp\Big(-\sum_a \lambda_a \, g_a(i) \Big).$$

Normalization fixes α and yields

$$\boxed{p_i = \frac{1}{Z} \exp\Big(-\sum_a \lambda_a \, g_a(i) \Big), \qquad Z = \sum_i \exp\Big(-\sum_a \lambda_a \, g_a(i) \Big).} \tag{1.4}$$

Since S is strictly concave in p and the constraints are linear, this stationary point is the unique maximum.

2 The Microcanonical Ensemble

The Boltzmann constant in the entropy. In thermodynamics, the Gibbs–Shannon entropy includes the Boltzmann constant k_B, which sets the entropy units:

$$\boxed{S(p) = -k_B \sum_{i=1}^{\Omega} p_i \ln p_i.} \tag{2.1}$$

For simplicity, k_B is set to 1 during derivations and restored in the final results.

From normalization alone to Boltzmann's entropy. The simplest case has normalization, $\sum_i p_i = 1$, as the only constraint. This case describes the microcanonical ensemble, an isolated system with fixed energy and other fixed macroscopic constraints. The energy is not imposed through a Lagrange multiplier. Instead, the energy restricts the sample space to the microstates with energy U, in practice a thin shell $[U, U + \delta U]$. The stationarity conditions of Eq. (1.3) are then

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial p_i} = -\ln p_i - 1 - \alpha = 0, \qquad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \alpha} = -\Big(\sum_i p_i - 1\Big) = 0.$$

The first condition gives $p_i = e^{-1-\alpha}$, which does not depend on i. Normalization then requires $\Omega\, e^{-1-\alpha} = 1$, so

$$\boxed{p_i = \frac{1}{\Omega}.} \tag{2.2}$$

The entropy maximum under normalization alone is therefore a uniform distribution, in which all accessible microstates are equally probable. The conventional approach postulates this property, whereas MaxEnt derives the property and thereby recovers Boltzmann's premise for the microcanonical ensemble. Substitution of $p_i = 1/\Omega$ into the entropy gives

$$S = -\sum_{i=1}^{\Omega} \frac{1}{\Omega} \ln \frac{1}{\Omega} = \ln \Omega,$$

and, with k_B restored, Boltzmann's microcanonical entropy is

$$\boxed{S = k_B \ln \Omega.} \tag{2.3}$$

Dependence of the entropy on the macroscopic constraints. The number of accessible microstates, Ω, is also called the microcanonical partition function. This number depends on the Hamiltonian $\mathcal{H}$ of the system and on the macroscopic constraints. The volume V, the particle number N and the internal energy U set the accessible microstates, so the entropy is a function of these three variables:

$$\boxed{S = S(N, V, U).} \tag{2.4}$$

Specified values of N, V and U therefore determine the equilibrium entropy uniquely.

3 The Canonical Ensemble

Constraining the average of an observable. The microcanonical ensemble does not distinguish between accessible microstates, so only their number matters. However, realistic systems obey constraints imposed by measurement. Suppose microstate i has a definite value a_i of an observable A, and the measured average is $\bar{A}$. The expectation value is

$$\boxed{\langle A\rangle \equiv \sum_i p_i a_i,} \tag{3.1}$$

and the constraint reads $\langle A\rangle = \bar{A}$. Here, $\langle A\rangle$ denotes the operation that extracts the mean of the observable A, and $\bar{A}$ denotes the numerical value assigned to that mean. Since only one constraint is present, the multiplier λ_a is renamed β. The Lagrangian now contains the multiplier α for normalization and the multiplier β for the constraint on $\langle A\rangle$. The stationarity conditions of this Lagrangian are

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial p_i} &= -\ln p_i - 1 - \alpha - \beta a_i = 0, \\
\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \alpha} &= -\Big(\sum_i p_i - 1\Big) = 0, \\
\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \beta} &= -\Big(\sum_i a_i p_i - \bar{A}\Big) = 0.
\end{aligned}$$

The Boltzmann distribution and the partition function. The first condition gives $p_i = e^{-1-\alpha-\beta a_i}$. Substitution of this result into the normalization condition and the constraint yields

$$e^{-1-\alpha}\sum_i e^{-\beta a_i} = 1, \qquad e^{-1-\alpha}\sum_i a_i e^{-\beta a_i} = \bar{A}.$$

The first equation determines α in terms of β and leaves a single free parameter. The canonical partition function is defined as

$$\boxed{Z(\beta) \equiv \sum_i e^{-\beta a_i},} \tag{3.2}$$

so the probability distribution becomes

$$\boxed{p_i = \frac{e^{-\beta a_i}}{Z(\beta)}.} \tag{3.3}$$

This result is the Boltzmann distribution. For $\beta > 0$, states with larger a_i are less probable. The remaining constraint, $\langle A\rangle(\beta) = \bar{A}$, determines β.

Uniqueness of the multiplier. The uniqueness of β follows from the mean expressed through Z:

$$\langle A\rangle = \frac{1}{Z}\sum_i a_i e^{-\beta a_i} = -\frac{\partial \ln Z}{\partial \beta}.$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\langle A\rangle = -\frac{\partial \ln Z}{\partial \beta}.} \tag{3.4}$$

With $\mathrm{Var}(A) \equiv \langle A^2\rangle - \langle A\rangle^2$, the derivative of the mean is

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial\langle A\rangle}{\partial\beta} &= \frac{\partial}{\partial\beta}\left(\frac{\sum_i a_i e^{-\beta a_i}}{Z}\right)\\ &= -\frac{\sum_i a_i^2 e^{-\beta a_i}}{Z} + \frac{1}{Z^2}\left(\sum_i a_i e^{-\beta a_i}\right)^2\\ &= -\langle A^2\rangle + \langle A\rangle^2 = -\mathrm{Var}(A),\end{aligned}$$

so

$$\boxed{\frac{\partial\langle A\rangle}{\partial\beta} = -\mathrm{Var}(A).} \tag{3.5}$$

Since $\mathrm{Var}(A) \geq 0$, $\langle A\rangle(\beta)$ is monotonically non-increasing. The mean is strictly decreasing whenever A takes more than one value over the accessible microstates. Thus, for target values in the interior of the achievable range, $\langle A\rangle$ determines β uniquely.

Entropy of the canonical distribution and the meaning of β. The entropy of the resulting distribution, with k_B omitted during the derivation, is

$$\begin{aligned}S &= -\sum_i p_i \ln p_i = -\sum_i p_i\left(-\beta a_i - \ln Z\right)\\ &= \beta\sum_i a_i p_i + \ln Z\sum_i p_i = \beta\langle A\rangle + \ln Z.\end{aligned}$$

With k_B restored,

$$\boxed{S = k_B\left(\beta\langle A\rangle + \ln Z\right).} \tag{3.6}$$

Although S depends on $\bar{A}$ both explicitly and implicitly through $\beta(\bar{A})$, the derivative of S reduces to β:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial S}{\partial\langle A\rangle} &= \beta + \langle A\rangle\frac{d\beta}{d\langle A\rangle} + \frac{\partial \ln Z}{\partial\beta}\frac{d\beta}{d\langle A\rangle}\\ &= \beta + \langle A\rangle\frac{d\beta}{d\langle A\rangle} - \langle A\rangle\frac{d\beta}{d\langle A\rangle} = \beta.\end{aligned}$$

With k_B restored, this result gives the meaning of the multiplier:

$$\boxed{\beta = \frac{1}{k_B}\frac{\partial S}{\partial\langle A\rangle}.} \tag{3.7}$$

Concavity of the entropy. A function f is concave on an interval I if, for all $x, y \in I$ and all $t \in [0,1]$,

$$\boxed{f\big(tx + (1-t)y\big) \;\geq\; t\,f(x) + (1-t)\,f(y).} \tag{3.8}$$

Geometrically, every chord lies on or below the graph. The function is strictly concave if the inequality is strict for $x \neq y$ and $t \in (0,1)$. For a twice-differentiable f, concavity is equivalent to $f'' \leq 0$, and $f'' < 0$ guarantees strict concavity. For S as a function of $\langle A \rangle$, the inverse-function rule and $\partial\langle A\rangle/\partial\beta = -\mathrm{Var}(A)$ give

$$\frac{\partial^2 S}{\partial \langle A\rangle^2} = \frac{d\beta}{d\langle A\rangle} = \left(\frac{d\langle A\rangle}{d\beta}\right)^{-1} = -\frac{1}{\mathrm{Var}(A)}.$$

With k_B restored,

$$\boxed{\frac{\partial^2 S}{\partial \langle A\rangle^2} = -\frac{k_B}{\mathrm{Var}(A)} < 0.} \tag{3.9}$$

The entropy is therefore strictly concave in $\langle A \rangle$ whenever A takes more than one value over the accessible microstates. This concavity is the monotonic decrease of $\langle A\rangle(\beta)$ viewed from the side of S, with each value of $\langle A\rangle$ corresponding to exactly one β.

Specialization to the internal energy. Since the observable A was never specified, the derivation applies to any observable with a constrained expectation value. The canonical ensemble conventionally fixes the volume V and the particle number N and constrains the internal energy. From here on, $A = U$, and U_i replaces a_i. The results become

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} Z(\beta) &= \sum_i e^{-\beta U_i}, \quad p_i = \frac{e^{-\beta U_i}}{Z(\beta)}, \\ \langle U\rangle &= -\frac{\partial \ln Z}{\partial \beta}, \qquad S = k_B\left(\beta\langle U\rangle + \ln Z\right). \end{aligned}} \tag{3.10}$$

Section 3.1 identifies β with the temperature. The end of this section explains why the particle number or the volume cannot be constrained alone.

Recovering the microcanonical ensemble. If every accessible microstate has the same energy U, the canonical ensemble reduces to the microcanonical ensemble. All the weights $e^{-\beta U}$ are identical, so the distribution is uniform and the mean energy equals U exactly. Then

$$\begin{aligned} Z &= \sum_{i=1}^{\Omega} e^{-\beta U} = \Omega\, e^{-\beta U}, \\ S &= k_B\left(\beta U + \ln\Omega - \beta U\right) = k_B \ln\Omega. \end{aligned}$$

3.1 First and Second Laws of Thermodynamics — Meaning of the Multipliers

The multipliers need thermodynamics for their meaning. The MaxEnt formalism does not by itself provide the physical interpretation or the numerical calibration of the multipliers. In particular, the identification

$$\boxed{\beta = \frac{1}{k_B}\frac{\partial S}{\partial \langle U\rangle} = \frac{1}{k_B T}} \tag{3.11}$$

cannot be derived from MaxEnt alone. This identification is an empirical correspondence established by classical thermodynamics. The physical meaning of the multipliers therefore comes from the thermodynamic laws.

From the first and second laws to the fundamental relation. The first law expresses energy conservation:

$$\boxed{dU = \delta Q - \delta W + \mu\, dN,} \tag{3.12}$$

where

- $\delta W = P\, dV$ is the work done *by* the system.
- The symbols δQ and δW emphasize that heat and work are not state functions, because their values depend on the path between two states.
- The chemical potential μ is the change in internal energy per added particle at fixed entropy and volume.

The second law, in the form of the Clausius inequality, states

$$\boxed{\delta Q \leq T\, dS,} \tag{3.13}$$

with equality for reversible processes. For a reversible process, the two laws combine to give

$$\boxed{dU = T\, dS - P\, dV + \mu\, dN,} \tag{3.14}$$

and therefore

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\right|_{V,N} = T, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial V}\right|_{S,N} = -P, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial N}\right|_{S,V} = \mu.} \tag{3.15}$$

The equivalent entropy form of Eq. (3.14) is

$$\boxed{dS = \frac{1}{T}\, dU + \frac{P}{T}\, dV - \frac{\mu}{T}\, dN,} \tag{3.16}$$

and therefore

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial S}{\partial U}\right|_{V,N} = \frac{1}{T}, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial S}{\partial V}\right|_{U,N} = \frac{P}{T}, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial S}{\partial N}\right|_{U,V} = -\frac{\mu}{T}.} \tag{3.17}$$

3.2 Extensive and Intensive Variables

Extensive and intensive variables and their conjugate pairs.

- A quantity X is extensive if, for two weakly coupled subsystems, $X_{\text{total}} = X_1 + X_2$. Equivalently, for λ identical, non-interacting copies, $X_\lambda = \lambda X_1$.

- A quantity Y is intensive if Y does not scale with the number of copies, $Y_\lambda = Y_1$.
- Energy, particle number, volume and entropy are extensive, whereas temperature, pressure and chemical potential are intensive.

This distinction explains why the Lagrange multipliers associated with extensive constraints are intensive. For any observable A with constrained average $\langle A \rangle$, the multiplier is

$$\beta_A \equiv \frac{1}{k_B} \frac{\partial S}{\partial \langle A \rangle}.$$

Because $\langle A \rangle$ and S are both extensive, their scaling factors cancel in the derivative, so β_A is intensive. Thermodynamic variables therefore come in conjugate pairs, each consisting of an extensive variable and its intensive conjugate.

Additivity of entropy follows from statistical independence. Here, the superscripts (1) and (2) also label the distributions of the two systems, $p_i^{(1)}$ and $p_j^{(2)}$. The partition function factorizes because the joint distribution factorizes, $p_{ij} = p_i^{(1)} p_j^{(2)}$. The entropy is then additive:

$$S_{1+2} = -\sum_{i,j} p_i^{(1)} p_j^{(2)} \ln\!\left(p_i^{(1)} p_j^{(2)}\right) = S_1 + S_2.$$

Additivity requires statistical independence but not equilibrium, so the two systems may have different multipliers β_1 and β_2:

$$\boxed{S_{1+2} = k_B \left(\beta_1 \langle U_1 \rangle + \ln Z_1 + \beta_2 \langle U_2 \rangle + \ln Z_2\right).} \tag{3.18}$$

Only when $\beta_1 = \beta_2 = \beta$, that is, when the two systems are in thermal equilibrium, does the joint system become canonical with a single multiplier:

$$\boxed{S_{1+2} = k_B \left[\beta \langle U_{1+2} \rangle + \ln Z_{1+2}\right], \qquad U_{1+2} = U_1 + U_2.} \tag{3.19}$$

Independence holds when the coupling between the systems is weak. For strong coupling, the joint distribution does not factorize, and $S_{1+2} = S_1 + S_2 - I$ with the mutual information $I \geq 0$.

3.3 Energy Fluctuation, Thermodynamic Limit and Equivalence of Ensembles

Energy fluctuation and the heat capacity. The variance of the internal energy, the energy fluctuation around the controlled mean $\langle U \rangle = \bar{U}$, can be expressed through familiar thermodynamic quantities. By the chain rule,

$$\mathrm{Var}(U) = -\frac{\partial \langle U \rangle}{\partial \beta} = -\frac{\partial \langle U \rangle}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial \beta}.$$

Since $T = 1/(k_B \beta)$, $\partial T / \partial \beta = -k_B T^2$. The isochoric heat capacity is defined as $C_V \equiv \partial \langle U \rangle / \partial T \big|_{V,N}$, at the fixed volume and particle number of the canonical ensemble. Substitution gives

$$\boxed{\mathrm{Var}(U) = k_B T^2 \, C_V.} \tag{3.20}$$

Why fluctuations vanish in the thermodynamic limit. The smallness of fluctuations is sometimes attributed to the tiny numerical value of k_B in SI units. This attribution is incorrect, because the value of k_B only reflects the choice of units. The genuine reason is that C_V and $\langle U \rangle$ are both extensive and scale linearly with the particle number N. Hence

$$\boxed{\frac{\sqrt{\mathrm{Var}(U)}}{\langle U \rangle} \sim \frac{\sqrt{N}}{N} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{N}},} \tag{3.21}$$

which vanishes as $N \to \infty$. The relative energy fluctuations of a macroscopic system are therefore negligible because of the sheer size of N. For this reason, U replaces $\langle U \rangle$ from here on, and likewise for other extensive variables. At large N, the canonical ensemble therefore behaves as the microcanonical ensemble, with negligible fluctuations and a one-to-one relation between energy and temperature.

Physical reading of the fluctuation formula. The multiplier β is smaller at higher temperature, so the entropic cost per unit of exchanged energy is smaller. The system then absorbs or releases energy more freely, consistent with the larger fluctuation $k_B T^2 C_V$.

Concavity of $S(U)$ and thermodynamic stability. For $A = U$, the concavity result and $\mathrm{Var}(U) = k_B T^2 C_V$ give

$$\boxed{\frac{\partial^2 S}{\partial U^2} = -\frac{k_B}{\mathrm{Var}(U)} = -\frac{1}{C_V\, T^2}.} \tag{3.22}$$

Concavity of $S(U)$ is therefore equivalent to $C_V > 0$, the thermodynamic stability condition, which requires that adding energy to a system raises the system temperature. This property is used again for the Legendre transformation in the next section.

3.4 Zeroth Law of Thermodynamics

Two bodies exchanging energy. Two bodies, (1) and (2), are in contact and can exchange energy. Two points need precise statements:

- The combined system $(1) + (2)$ is genuinely isolated and exchanges nothing with the outside. The total energy is a hard constraint, $U_1 + U_2 = U_{\mathrm{tot}}$, so whatever one body releases, the other receives. This constraint is a microcanonical condition on the pair as a whole.
- Each body has an entropy function $S_i(U_i, V_i, N_i)$, which is the canonical entropy derived earlier in this section. Each body carries the multiplier $\beta_i \equiv k_B^{-1}\, \partial S_i / \partial U_i$ attached to the energy of that body. The pair is microcanonical, whereas each body behaves canonically, with the other body as the energy reservoir.

Equilibrium requires equal multipliers. The two bodies are weakly coupled, so the combined entropy is additive, $S = S_1 + S_2$. Equilibrium corresponds to the maximum of S with respect to how U_{tot} is shared. The substitution $U_2 = U_{\text{tot}} - U_1$ and differentiation with respect to U_1 give

$$\frac{\partial S}{\partial U_1} = \frac{\partial S_1}{\partial U_1} + \frac{\partial S_2}{\partial U_2}\frac{\partial U_2}{\partial U_1} = \frac{\partial S_1}{\partial U_1} - \frac{\partial S_2}{\partial U_2} = 0.$$

Since $\beta_i = k_B^{-1}\,\partial S_i/\partial U_i$, this condition gives

$$\boxed{\beta_1 = \beta_2 \qquad \text{and hence} \qquad T_1 = T_2.} \tag{3.23}$$

Direction of energy flow and the zeroth law. Suppose $\beta_1 \neq \beta_2$ initially. A small energy transfer δU_1 into body (1) changes the total entropy by

$$\delta S = k_B(\beta_1 - \beta_2)\,\delta U_1.$$

The second law requires $\delta S \geq 0$, so energy flows into the body with the larger β, that is, the lower T. Energy therefore flows from high temperature to low temperature. A third body in contact with both bodies reaches the same β at equilibrium by the same argument. This transitivity is the zeroth law of thermodynamics.

Volume and particle exchange cannot be separated from energy exchange. Suppose the two bodies can also exchange volume through a movable partition, with $V_1 + V_2 = V_{\text{tot}}$ fixed. Volume exchange does not by itself imply thermal contact. A heat-insulating piston that slides freely permits volume exchange but forbids heat exchange, so $T_1 \neq T_2$ in general. The multiplier conjugate to volume is $\beta_V \equiv k_B^{-1}\,\partial S/\partial V = P/(k_B T)$. The maximum of $S = S_1(V_1) + S_2(V_2)$ over the split of V_{tot}, with U_1 and U_2 fixed, satisfies

$$\beta_{V,1} = \beta_{V,2} \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \frac{P_1}{T_1} = \frac{P_2}{T_2}.$$

This condition permits $P_1 \neq P_2$. However, by Newton's second law alone, a partition under a genuine pressure imbalance cannot rest. The flaw is the assumption that U_1 and U_2 stay fixed while the partition moves. A sliding wall does work $P\,dV$ on the side toward which the wall moves, so even a heat-insulating wall exchanges energy through work, $dU = -P\,dV$ for $\delta Q = 0$. If energy and volume can both be exchanged, as for a movable wall that also conducts heat, the maximum of $S_1(U_1, V_1) + S_2(U_2, V_2)$ over both splits satisfies

$$\boxed{T_1 = T_2 \quad \text{and} \quad P_1 = P_2,} \tag{3.24}$$

the physically sensible free-piston equilibrium.

Why the multipliers of V and N contain the temperature. More generally, volume or particle exchange always involves energy exchange. Each exchange contributes its own term to the first law, $-P\,dV$ or $\mu\,dN$, so the energy varies whenever either quantity varies freely. The multipliers conjugate to volume and particle number therefore always appear together with the temperature.

4 Beyond Canonical Ensemble

4.1 Internal Energy Minimization

Two ways to slice the entropy landscape. Consider the entropy $S(U, X)$ as a surface over the (X, U) plane, where X is an extensive variable that can be freely partitioned, such as a volume shared between two bodies. The level curves of S, the curves along which S is constant, resemble contour lines on a topographic map. The map can be sliced in two ways:

- Entropy maximum at fixed U. Along a horizontal line, $U = \text{const}$, the highest contour reached touches the line without crossing the line, so the contour is tangent to the line.
- Energy minimum at fixed S. Along one contour, $S = \text{const}$, the lowest point has a horizontal tangent.

Both slices therefore select a point where the level curve of S has a horizontal tangent in the (X, U) plane.

One geometric condition, two descriptions. The gradient

$$\nabla S = \left(\frac{\partial S}{\partial X}, \frac{\partial S}{\partial U} \right)$$

is perpendicular to the level curve. If $\partial S/\partial X = 0$ at a point, the gradient points purely along the U-direction, so the level curve points purely along the X-direction and is horizontal. A horizontal tangent means $dU/dX|_S = 0$, a stationary point of U along the contour. The implicit function theorem makes this condition explicit:

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial X}\right|_S = -\frac{\partial S/\partial X\,|_U}{\partial S/\partial U\,|_X}.} \tag{4.1}$$

Since $\partial S/\partial U = 1/T$ is finite and nonzero, the left side vanishes exactly when the numerator vanishes:

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial S}{\partial X}\right|_U = 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial X}\right|_S = 0.} \tag{4.2}$$

The two conditions are equivalent because they describe the same point on the same contour line.

Generality of the argument and the role of stability. This argument does not depend on entropy or energy. For any smooth function $f(x, y)$ that is monotonic in y at fixed x, the points where f is extremal in x at fixed y coincide with the points where y is extremal in x along a level set of f, because both conditions say that the contour is flat. Thermodynamics is the case $f = S$ and $y = U$, with x any extensive variable, and monotonicity follows from $\partial S/\partial U = 1/T > 0$. The thermodynamic stability condition, $\partial^2 S/\partial X^2 < 0$, adds the type of flat point, with a maximum of S at fixed U corresponding to a minimum of U at fixed S.

Which flat point: maximum of S, minimum of U. Differentiation of $\partial U/\partial X|_S = -T\,\partial S/\partial X|_U$ once more along a contour of constant S gives

$$\left.\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial X^2}\right|_S = -T\left.\frac{d}{dX}\right|_S\left(\left.\frac{\partial S}{\partial X}\right|_U\right) - \left.\frac{\partial T}{\partial X}\right|_S\left.\frac{\partial S}{\partial X}\right|_U.$$

At the stationary point, $\partial S/\partial X|_U = 0$ and $\partial U/\partial X|_S = 0$, so the second term vanishes and the chain rule reduces the first term to $\partial^2 S/\partial X^2|_U$:

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial^2 U}{\partial X^2}\right|_S = -T\left.\frac{\partial^2 S}{\partial X^2}\right|_U.} \tag{4.3}$$

Since $T > 0$ and $\partial^2 S/\partial X^2 < 0$ by stability, the right side is positive. A maximum of S at fixed U is therefore a minimum of U at fixed S.

4.2 Thermodynamic Potential

Entropy as the microcanonical thermodynamic potential. The microcanonical entropy $S(U, V, N)$ is a function of state, because the values of U, V and N determine S completely. The derivatives of S give every conjugate intensive variable, and S is the quantity extremized by the ensemble. For these reasons, S is called the thermodynamic potential of the ensemble, and (U, V, N) are the natural variables. A potential $\Psi(x_1, \ldots, x_n)$ has natural variables $(x_1, \ldots, x_n)$ when:

(i) the derivatives of Ψ with respect to the x_i give every conjugate variable, so $d\Psi$ is an exact differential in exactly these variables, with nothing missing and nothing required from outside;

(ii) the x_i are precisely the quantities externally fixed or controlled under the physical condition that Ψ describes, that is, the hard constraints of the ensemble, not an arbitrary choice of variables.

The need for a potential with natural variables (N, V, T). Because S is strictly increasing in U, the relation $S(U, V, N)$ can be inverted to give $U(S, V, N)$, which is also a function of state. The derivatives of U likewise give T, P and μ, and U is minimized at fixed (S, V, N). However, the canonical ensemble controls the temperature rather than U. The entropy is then known only as a consequence of T, not as a freely varied coordinate. The canonical ensemble therefore needs a potential that preserves the full information of the system and has the natural variables (N, V, T).

4.3 The Legendre Transformation

Constructing the transform from tangent lines. In this section, ξ denotes the slope instead of p, to avoid confusion with the probability p_i and the pressure P. Let $f(x)$ be a function. At each point x, the tangent line has slope $\xi(x) = f'(x)$ and intercept $f(x) - \xi(x)\,x$. The intercept, expressed as a function of the slope, is the Legendre transform

$$\boxed{g(\xi) = f(x) - \xi\,x, \qquad \xi = f'(x).} \tag{4.4}$$

The transform $g(\xi)$ conserves the information of $f(x)$ if f can be reconstructed from g alone.

Reconstructing f from its transform. The tangent line with slope ξ is $y = \xi x + g(\xi)$, so the tangent lines form a family with one line per ξ. At a fixed point x, the vertical gap between this family and the curve is

$$\Delta(\xi, x) = \xi x + g(\xi) - f(x).$$

A function f is convex if $-f$ is concave, that is, if the inequality in the definition of concavity is reversed. If f is convex, every tangent line lies on or below the curve, so $\Delta \leq 0$ for all ξ, with equality exactly for the line tangent at x. If f is concave, every tangent line lies on or above the curve, so $\Delta \geq 0$ with the same equality condition. In either case, the tangent line is a genuine extremum of Δ over ξ, not merely a stationary point:

$$\frac{\partial \Delta}{\partial \xi} = x + g'(\xi) = 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad x = -g'(\xi).$$

With the solution denoted $\xi^*(x)$, f is reconstructed as

$$\boxed{x = -g'(\xi), \qquad f(x) = \xi^*(x)\, x + g\big[\xi^*(x)\big].} \tag{4.5}$$

Hence f and g determine each other, and no information is lost. The transformation trades the variable x for the conjugate $\xi = f'(x)$.

4.4 Multivariable Legendre Transformation

Extending the transform to several variables. Let $f(x_1, \ldots, x_n)$ be a function of $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \ldots, x_n)$. At each point, the tangent hyperplane has gradient $\boldsymbol{\xi}(\mathbf{x}) = \nabla f(\mathbf{x})$, with components $\xi_i = \partial f / \partial x_i$, and intercept $f - \boldsymbol{\xi} \cdot \mathbf{x}$. The Legendre transform is

$$\boxed{g(\boldsymbol{\xi}) = f(\mathbf{x}) - \boldsymbol{\xi} \cdot \mathbf{x} = f(\mathbf{x}) - \sum_{i=1}^{n} \xi_i x_i.} \tag{4.6}$$

Reconstructing f from its transform. The tangent hyperplane with gradient $\boldsymbol{\xi}$ is $y = \boldsymbol{\xi} \cdot \mathbf{x} + g(\boldsymbol{\xi})$, so the hyperplanes form a family with one member for each $\boldsymbol{\xi} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. At a fixed point $\mathbf{x}$, the vertical gap between this family and the surface is

$$\Delta(\boldsymbol{\xi}, \mathbf{x}) = \boldsymbol{\xi} \cdot \mathbf{x} + g(\boldsymbol{\xi}) - f(\mathbf{x}).$$

If f is convex, every tangent hyperplane lies on or below the surface, so $\Delta \leq 0$ for all $\boldsymbol{\xi}$, with equality exactly for the hyperplane tangent at $\mathbf{x}$. If f is concave, $\Delta \geq 0$ with the same equality condition. In either case, that is, when the Hessian of f is semidefinite everywhere, the tangent hyperplane is a genuine extremum of Δ over $\boldsymbol{\xi}$:

$$\frac{\partial \Delta}{\partial \xi_i} = x_i + \frac{\partial g}{\partial \xi_i} = 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad x_i = -\frac{\partial g}{\partial \xi_i} \qquad (i = 1, \ldots, n).$$

With the solution denoted $\boldsymbol{\xi}^*(\mathbf{x})$, f is reconstructed as

$$\boxed{x_i = -\frac{\partial g}{\partial \xi_i}, \qquad f(\mathbf{x}) = \boldsymbol{\xi}^*(\mathbf{x}) \cdot \mathbf{x} + g\big[\boldsymbol{\xi}^*(\mathbf{x})\big].} \tag{4.7}$$

No information is lost. The transformation trades the variables $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ for their conjugates $\xi_i = \partial f / \partial x_i$.

Partial Legendre transforms. In thermodynamics, a Legendre transform often acts on only a subset $I \subseteq \{1, \dots, n\}$ of the variables and leaves the rest untouched:

$$\boxed{g\big(\{\xi_i\}_{i\in I}, \{x_j\}_{j\notin I}\big) = f(\mathbf{x}) - \sum_{i\in I} \xi_i x_i, \qquad \xi_i = \left.\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_i}\right|_{\mathbf{x}}.} \tag{4.8}$$

The construction above goes through one variable at a time. Each x_i with $i \in I$ is swapped for the conjugate ξ_i, and each x_j with $j \notin I$ is held fixed as a spectator.

Convexity of partial transforms. If f is convex, a partial Legendre transform is concave in the transformed variables ξ_i and convex in the untransformed variables x_j. Since $U(S, V, N)$ is convex by thermodynamic stability, $F(T, V, N)$ is concave in T and convex in V, and $H(S, P, N)$ is concave in P and convex in S. For this reason, F is minimized over V at fixed T but not over T.

4.5 NVT Ensemble — Helmholtz Free Energy

Helmholtz free energy as the Legendre transform of U. The thermodynamic potential of the *NVT* ensemble, or canonical ensemble, is the Helmholtz free energy. The Helmholtz free energy is the partial Legendre transform of $U(S, V, N)$ that trades S for the conjugate $T = \partial U/\partial S|_{V,N}$:

$$F(N, V, T) = U - \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\right|_{V,N} S,$$

that is,

$$\boxed{F(N, V, T) = U - TS.} \tag{4.9}$$

Conjugate variables of F. The free energy F generates every conjugate variable. Because U depends on S, and S in turn depends on T, V and N, each derivative of F includes the contribution of S:

$$\begin{aligned}
\left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial T}\right|_{V,N} &= \frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\frac{\partial S}{\partial T} - S - T\frac{\partial S}{\partial T} = -S, \\
\left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial V}\right|_{T,N} &= \frac{\partial U}{\partial V} + \frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\frac{\partial S}{\partial V} - T\frac{\partial S}{\partial V} = -P + T\frac{\partial S}{\partial V} - T\frac{\partial S}{\partial V} = -P, \\
\left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial N}\right|_{T,V} &= \frac{\partial U}{\partial N} + \frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\frac{\partial S}{\partial N} - T\frac{\partial S}{\partial N} = \mu + T\frac{\partial S}{\partial N} - T\frac{\partial S}{\partial N} = \mu.
\end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial T}\right|_{V,N} = -S, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial V}\right|_{T,N} = -P, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial F}{\partial N}\right|_{T,V} = \mu.} \tag{4.10}$$

Thus, F behaves much like U, with the same dimension and the same P and μ, whereas T has become an argument and $-S$ the conjugate.

Minimization of F from entropy maximization. The minimization of F follows from MaxEnt applied to the combined system. A system at fixed V and N exchanges energy with a reservoir at temperature T, and the pair is isolated, as in the zeroth-law setup. The reservoir gains the energy that the system loses, so $dS_{\text{res}} = -dU/T$, and the total entropy changes by

$$\boxed{dS_{\text{tot}} = dS - \frac{dU}{T} = -\frac{dF}{T} \geq 0.} \tag{4.11}$$

The maximum of the total entropy is therefore the minimum of the system free energy F. The term $-TS$ in F accounts for the reservoir.

Free energy and the partition function. Substitution of $S = k_B(\beta U + \ln Z)$ and $\beta = 1/(k_B T)$ into $F = U - TS$ gives

$$F = U - \frac{1}{k_B \beta}\, k_B\, (\beta U + \ln Z) = U - U - \frac{\ln Z}{\beta},$$

so

$$\boxed{F = -k_B T \ln Z.} \tag{4.12}$$

4.6 NPS Ensemble — Enthalpy

Enthalpy as the Legendre transform of U in the volume. For some systems, the pressure is more natural to control than the volume, because the pressure is intensive and does not depend on the system size. The thermodynamic potential is then the enthalpy, the partial Legendre transform of $U(S, V, N)$ that trades V for the conjugate $-P = \partial U/\partial V|_{S,N}$:

$$H(N, P, S) = U - \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial V}\right|_{S,N} V,$$

that is,

$$\boxed{H(N, P, S) = U + PV.} \tag{4.13}$$

This ensemble is labeled the NPS ensemble after the natural variables of H. The enthalpy generates every conjugate variable:

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial H}{\partial S}\right|_{P,N} = T, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial H}{\partial P}\right|_{S,N} = V, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial H}{\partial N}\right|_{S,P} = \mu.} \tag{4.14}$$

Enthalpy as exchanged heat, and its minimization. By the first law, at constant (N, P),

$$\boxed{\delta Q = dU + P\, dV = dH.} \tag{4.15}$$

The Clausius inequality, $\delta Q \leq T\, dS$, then gives $dH \leq T\, dS$, and at constant entropy

$$\boxed{dH \leq 0.} \tag{4.16}$$

Any spontaneous process at fixed (N, P, S) therefore proceeds toward lower H and halts at the minimum of H, which recovers the equilibrium condition established earlier. However, most processes are not isentropic, so the enthalpy is mainly used as the heat exchanged at fixed pressure. For example, the enthalpy measures the heat of a phase transition.

Labels and conventional names of ensembles. From here on, each ensemble is labeled by the natural variables of the thermodynamic potential, such as NVT for F and NPS for H. The conventional name is given alongside. The conventional label of an ensemble lists the quantities held fixed as constraints. For NPS, the conventional name is the isoenthalpic-isobaric ensemble, NPH, which fixes N, P and the enthalpy H. The NPH ensemble relates to $H(N, P, S)$ as the microcanonical ensemble NVU relates to $U(S, V, N)$, with the same state described either by the fixed energy-like quantity or by the entropy. Table 1 lists the ensembles of this section and the next.

Table 1: Natural variables, potentials and conventional names of the ensembles.

Natural variables	Potential	Conventional name
(S, V, N)	U	microcanonical (NVU)
(T, V, N)	F	canonical (NVT)
(S, P, N)	H	isoenthalpic-isobaric (NPH)
(T, V, μ)	grand potential	grand canonical (μVT)
(T, P, N)	G	isothermal-isobaric (NPT)

5 The Grand Canonical Ensemble

Adding a second constraint: particle exchange. The grand canonical ensemble adds a second constrained average, the particle number, so the system exchanges both energy and particles with the surroundings. Here, β and γ denote the multipliers of the constraints $\langle U\rangle = \bar{U}$ and $\langle N\rangle = \bar{N}$, and U_i and N_i denote the energy and particle number of microstate i. The stationarity conditions of the Lagrangian are

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial p_i} = -\ln p_i - 1 - \alpha - \beta U_i - \gamma N_i = 0, \qquad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \alpha} = -\Big(\sum_i p_i - 1\Big) = 0,$$
$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \beta} = -\Big(\sum_i U_i p_i - \bar{U}\Big) = 0, \qquad \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \gamma} = -\Big(\sum_i N_i p_i - \bar{N}\Big) = 0.$$

The grand canonical distribution. The first condition gives $p_i = e^{-1-\alpha-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i}$. Normalization fixes α, and the remaining conditions fix the averages:

$$e^{1+\alpha} = \sum_i e^{-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i}, \qquad \bar{U} = \frac{\sum_i U_i\, e^{-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i}}{\sum_i e^{-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i}}, \qquad \bar{N} = \frac{\sum_i N_i\, e^{-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i}}{\sum_i e^{-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i}}.$$

The free parameters are now β and γ, as β alone is in the canonical ensemble, and α is a normalization factor that depends on both. The grand canonical partition function is defined as

$$\boxed{\Xi(\beta,\gamma) \equiv \sum_i e^{-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i},} \tag{5.1}$$

and the probability of a microstate with energy U_i and N_i particles is

$$\boxed{p_i = \frac{e^{-\beta U_i-\gamma N_i}}{\Xi(\beta,\gamma)}.} \tag{5.2}$$

Identifying γ with the chemical potential. The entropy of this distribution is

$$\frac{S}{k_B} = -\sum_i p_i \ln p_i = \beta\langle U\rangle + \gamma\langle N\rangle + \ln \Xi.$$

In the differential of S, with $\partial \ln \Xi/\partial\beta = -\langle U\rangle$ and $\partial \ln \Xi/\partial\gamma = -\langle N\rangle$, the terms from the implicit dependence cancel, as in the canonical case:

$$dS = k_B\left(\beta\, d\langle U\rangle + \gamma\, d\langle N\rangle\right), \qquad \text{so} \qquad \gamma = \frac{1}{k_B}\frac{\partial S}{\partial \langle N\rangle}\bigg|_{\langle U\rangle, V}.$$

The first law gives $\partial S/\partial N|_{U,V} = -\mu/T$, hence $\gamma = -\beta\mu$. Like $\beta = 1/(k_B T)$, this relation is a correspondence with classical thermodynamics. From here on, (β,μ) replaces (β,γ). The results become

$$\boxed{\Xi(\beta,\mu) = \sum_i e^{-\beta(U_i-\mu N_i)}, \qquad p_i = \frac{e^{-\beta(U_i-\mu N_i)}}{\Xi(\beta,\mu)},} \tag{5.3}$$

and the entropy is

$$\boxed{S = k_B\left[\beta\left(\langle U\rangle - \mu\langle N\rangle\right) + \ln \Xi\right].} \tag{5.4}$$

Energy and particle number are correlated. Particle exchange also exchanges energy, as the zeroth-law discussion showed. Therefore, $\langle U \rangle$ alone is expected to be a poor function of β at fixed μ. The covariance of two observables X and Y is defined as

$$\boxed{\mathrm{Cov}(X,Y) \equiv \langle XY \rangle - \langle X \rangle \langle Y \rangle, \qquad \mathrm{Var}(X) = \mathrm{Cov}(X,X).} \tag{5.5}$$

Let $w_i = U_i - \mu N_i$. For any observable X, at fixed V and μ,

$$\begin{aligned} \left.\frac{\partial \langle X \rangle}{\partial \beta}\right|_{V,\mu} &= \frac{\partial}{\partial \beta}\left(\frac{\sum_i X_i e^{-\beta w_i}}{\Xi}\right) \\ &= -\frac{\sum_i X_i w_i e^{-\beta w_i}}{\Xi} + \frac{\left(\sum_i X_i e^{-\beta w_i}\right)\left(\sum_j w_j e^{-\beta w_j}\right)}{\Xi^2} \\ &= -\langle X w \rangle + \langle X \rangle \langle w \rangle = -\mathrm{Cov}(X,w). \end{aligned}$$

For $X = U$ and $X = w$, this result gives

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial \langle U \rangle}{\partial \beta}\right|_{V,\mu} = -\mathrm{Var}(U) + \mu\,\mathrm{Cov}(U,N).} \tag{5.6}$$

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial}{\partial \beta}\left(\langle U \rangle - \mu \langle N \rangle\right)\right|_{V,\mu} = -\mathrm{Var}(U - \mu N).} \tag{5.7}$$

The monotonicity of $\langle U \rangle(\beta)$ depends on the sign of $\mu\,\mathrm{Cov}(U,N)$. The combination $\langle U \rangle - \mu \langle N \rangle$ always decreases with β, like $\langle U \rangle$ in the canonical ensemble. This combination follows from Ξ in the same way:

$$\boxed{\langle U \rangle - \mu \langle N \rangle = -\left.\frac{\partial \ln \Xi}{\partial \beta}\right|_{V,\mu}.} \tag{5.8}$$

Uniqueness of the multipliers. The multipliers (β, γ) are determined uniquely by the constrained means $(\langle U \rangle, \langle N \rangle)$ whenever the map between them is injective. Since $\langle U \rangle = -\partial \ln \Xi / \partial \beta$ and $\langle N \rangle = -\partial \ln \Xi / \partial \gamma$, the Jacobian of this map is minus the Hessian of $\ln \Xi$. By the covariance formula above, this Hessian is the covariance matrix of (U, N):

$$\boxed{\nabla^2_{(\beta,\gamma)} \ln \Xi = \begin{pmatrix} \mathrm{Var}(U) & \mathrm{Cov}(U,N) \\ \mathrm{Cov}(U,N) & \mathrm{Var}(N) \end{pmatrix} \equiv C.} \tag{5.9}$$

A covariance matrix is positive semidefinite. The matrix is positive definite unless some combination $aU_i + bN_i$ takes the same value in every accessible microstate. In the generic case, $\ln \Xi$ is strictly convex, so the gradient map of $\ln \Xi$ is injective. Each interior pair $(\bar{U}, \bar{N})$ therefore corresponds to exactly one pair (β, γ). This result extends the uniqueness argument of the canonical ensemble to two constraints.

5.1 Particle Number Fluctuation, Thermodynamic Limit and Equivalence of Ensembles Revisited

Particle number fluctuation. The particle number fluctuation is the variance of N. At fixed β and V, the weights depend on μ through $e^{\beta\mu N_i}$, so the derivative of the mean is

$$\left.\frac{\partial\langle N\rangle}{\partial\mu}\right|_{T,V} = \beta\left(\langle N^2\rangle - \langle N\rangle^2\right) = \beta\,\mathrm{Var}(N).$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\mathrm{Var}(N) = k_B T \left.\frac{\partial\langle N\rangle}{\partial\mu}\right|_{T,V}.} \tag{5.10}$$

The thermodynamic limit. The derivative of an extensive variable with respect to an intensive variable is extensive, so $\mathrm{Var}(N) \sim N$ and

$$\boxed{\frac{\sqrt{\mathrm{Var}(N)}}{\langle N\rangle} \sim \frac{1}{\sqrt{N}}.} \tag{5.11}$$

As for the energy in the canonical ensemble, particle fluctuations are negligible because of the sheer size of N. Therefore, N replaces $\langle N\rangle$, and U replaces $\langle U\rangle$, from here on. For very large N, the grand canonical ensemble converges to the microcanonical ensemble. The microcanonical ensemble can then be used to solve idealized versions of realistic thermodynamic systems analytically.

5.2 μVT Ensemble — Grand Potential

The grand potential. The natural variables of the grand canonical ensemble are (μ, V, T), hence the label μVT ensemble. As in the canonical ensemble, T controls the internal energy, and the chemical potential μ likewise controls the particle number. The thermodynamic potential is the grand potential, the partial Legendre transform of $U(S, V, N)$ in S and N:

$$\Phi(\mu, V, T) = U - \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\right|_{V,N} S - \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial N}\right|_{S,V} N,$$

that is,

$$\boxed{\Phi(\mu, V, T) = U - TS - \mu N = F - \mu N.} \tag{5.12}$$

Conjugate variables of Φ. From $dU = T\,dS - P\,dV + \mu\,dN$,

$$d\Phi = dU - T\,dS - S\,dT - \mu\,dN - N\,d\mu = -S\,dT - P\,dV - N\,d\mu,$$

so

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial\Phi}{\partial T}\right|_{V,\mu} = -S, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial\Phi}{\partial V}\right|_{T,\mu} = -P, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial\Phi}{\partial\mu}\right|_{T,V} = -N.} \tag{5.13}$$

Minimization of Φ at fixed (μ, V, T). At fixed V, $\delta W = 0$, so the first law gives $\delta Q = dU - \mu\, dN$. The Clausius inequality, $\delta Q \le T\, dS$, then gives $dU - \mu\, dN \le T\, dS$, and at fixed μ and T

$$\boxed{d\Phi = dU - \mu\, dN - T\, dS \le 0.} \tag{5.14}$$

Any spontaneous process at fixed (μ, V, T) therefore proceeds toward lower Φ and halts at the minimum of Φ.

Grand potential and the partition function. With $S = k_B[\beta(U - \mu N) + \ln \Xi]$ and $\beta = 1/(k_B T)$,

$$\Phi = U - \mu N - TS = (U - \mu N) - \frac{1}{k_B \beta}\, k_B\, [\beta(U - \mu N) + \ln \Xi] = -\frac{\ln \Xi}{\beta},$$

so

$$\boxed{\Phi = -k_B T \ln \Xi.} \tag{5.15}$$

5.3 NPT Ensemble — Gibbs Free Energy

The Gibbs free energy. The NPT ensemble, conventionally the isothermal-isobaric ensemble, is the ensemble most used in experiments. The ensemble controls the particle number N, the pressure P and the temperature T, and the system exchanges both energy and volume with the surroundings. Like the μVT ensemble, the NPT ensemble has two intensive natural variables, P and T. The thermodynamic potential is the Gibbs free energy, the partial Legendre transform of $U(S, V, N)$ in S and V:

$$G(T, P, N) = U - \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\right|_{V,N} S - \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial V}\right|_{S,N} V,$$

that is,

$$\boxed{G(T, P, N) = U - TS + PV = F + PV = H - TS.} \tag{5.16}$$

Conjugate variables of G. From $dG = -S\, dT + V\, dP + \mu\, dN$,

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial G}{\partial T}\right|_{P,N} = -S, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial G}{\partial P}\right|_{T,N} = V, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial G}{\partial N}\right|_{T,P} = \mu.} \tag{5.17}$$

Minimization of G at fixed (N, P, T). At fixed N, the first law gives $\delta Q = dU + P\, dV$, and the Clausius inequality gives $dU + P\, dV \le T\, dS$. At fixed P and T,

$$\boxed{dG = dU - T\, dS + P\, dV \le 0.} \tag{5.18}$$

Any spontaneous process at fixed (N, P, T) therefore proceeds toward lower G and halts at the minimum of G.

The NPT ensemble from MaxEnt. The NPT ensemble arises from the same principle as the other ensembles. The average volume is constrained, $\langle V\rangle = \bar{V}$, with a multiplier β_V, and the microstates include the volume, with the sum over V replaced by an integral if V is continuous. The general solution gives $p_i \propto e^{-\beta U_i - \beta_V V_i}$. As in the earlier cases, $\beta_V = \frac{1}{k_B}\partial S/\partial\langle V\rangle = \beta P$, because $\partial S/\partial V|_{U,N} = P/T$. With the partition function

$$\Gamma(\beta, P) = \sum_i e^{-\beta(U_i + PV_i)},$$

the entropy is $S = k_B[\beta(\langle U\rangle + P\langle V\rangle) + \ln\Gamma]$, and the potential is

$$\boxed{G = U + PV - TS = -k_B T \ln\Gamma.} \tag{5.19}$$

All five ensembles therefore follow from entropy maximization under different sets of constraints.

5.4 Euler's Homogeneous Function Theorem

Extensive variables as functions of other variables. The variables have been classified as extensive or intensive, but the dependence of one extensive variable on the others has not yet been studied. Euler's (homogeneous function) theorem is a general calculus statement for functions with a scaling property. A function $f(x_1, \ldots, x_n)$ is homogeneous of degree k if

$$\boxed{f(\lambda x_1, \ldots, \lambda x_n) = \lambda^k f(x_1, \ldots, x_n).} \tag{5.20}$$

Euler's theorem. If f is differentiable on $\mathbb{R}^n$ and homogeneous of degree k, then

$$\boxed{\sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_i} = k\, f(x_1, \ldots, x_n).} \tag{5.21}$$

Proof of the theorem. The derivative of the defining relation with respect to λ, with $y_i = \lambda x_i$, follows from the chain rule:

$$\sum_{i=1}^{n} \left.\frac{\partial f}{\partial y_i}\right|_{y=\lambda x} x_i = k\lambda^{k-1} f(x_1, \ldots, x_n).$$

The theorem follows for $\lambda = 1$.

Application to the internal energy. The internal energy is homogeneous of degree one:

$$U(\lambda S, \lambda V, \lambda N) = \lambda\, U(S, V, N).$$

Euler's theorem then gives

$$\boxed{U = \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial S}\right|_{V,N} S + \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial V}\right|_{S,N} V + \left.\frac{\partial U}{\partial N}\right|_{S,V} N = TS - PV + \mu N.} \tag{5.22}$$

This Euler relation is a relation between values, not a statement about the variables of U. The natural variables of U remain (S, V, N), and (T, P, μ) are functions of these variables, computed from the derivatives of U. The intensive variables cannot be treated as variables of U, because scaling the system changes U but leaves (T, P, μ) unchanged.

Potentials with fewer extensive variables. The particle number N is the only extensive natural variable of the NPT ensemble, so G scales with N alone:

$$G(\lambda N, P, T) = \lambda\, G(N, P, T).$$

Euler's theorem then gives $G = \mu N$ for a single-component system, the formula commonly used in chemistry. The same argument applies to every potential, and each potential follows from subtracting the transformed terms from $U = TS - PV + \mu N$:

$$\begin{aligned} F &= U - TS = -PV + \mu N, & H &= U + PV = TS + \mu N, \\ \Phi &= U - TS - \mu N = -PV, & G &= U - TS + PV = \mu N. \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} F(N, V, T) &= -PV + \mu N, & H(N, P, S) &= TS + \mu N, \\ \Phi(\mu, V, T) &= -PV, & G(N, P, T) &= \mu N. \end{aligned}} \tag{5.23}$$

Ensembles with one intensive natural variable, NVT and NPS, have a potential that depends on two extensive variables. Ensembles with two intensive natural variables, μVT and NPT, have a potential that depends on one extensive variable only.

5.5 Multi-Component System

Generalization to several species. The preceding sections treated a single species, but realistic systems contain several species. Species i has the particle number N_i and the chemical potential μ_i. The pairs (μ_i, N_i) are conjugate, like the pair (μ, N) used so far, and each species adds one degree of freedom. From here on, $\sum_i \mu_i N_i$ replaces every term μN in a Legendre transformation. Euler's theorem becomes

$$\boxed{U = TS - PV + \sum_i \mu_i N_i,} \tag{5.24}$$

and all earlier results carry over.

Relations between the potentials. Figure 1 shows how Legendre transformations connect the potentials.

Summary of the ensembles. Table 2 lists the fixed variables of each ensemble and the derivatives of the potential that give the remaining variables.

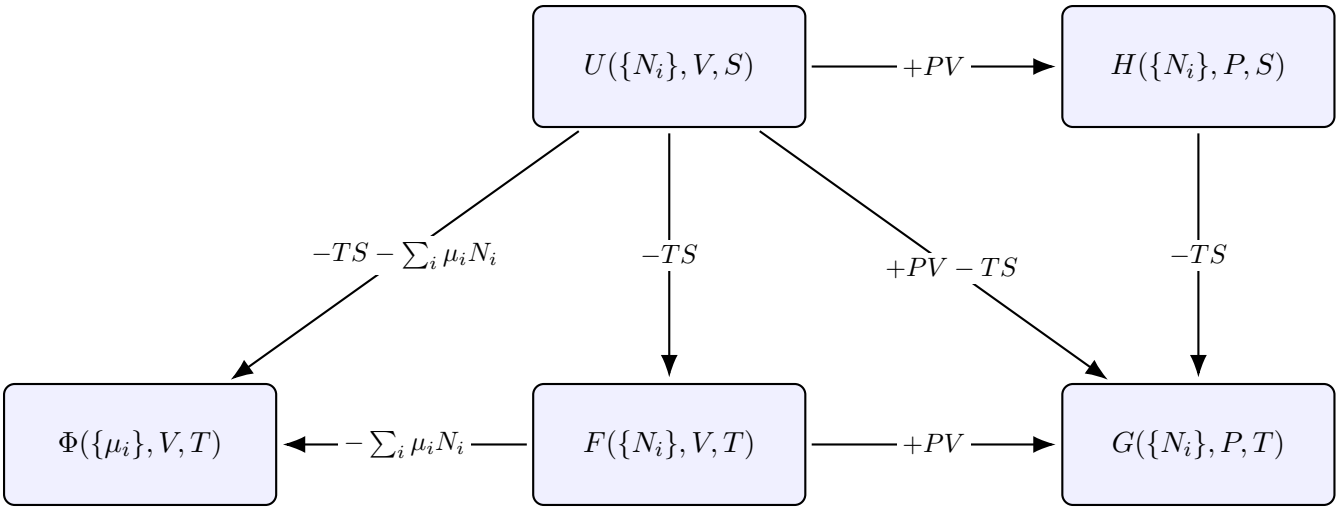


Figure 1: Legendre transformations connecting the thermodynamic potentials.

5.6 Mixing Entropy and the Gibbs Paradox

Setting and the two properties of the entropy. Let $X = (U, V, N_1, N_2)$ denote the extensive variables and $S(X) = k_B \ln \Omega(X)$ the microcanonical entropy. The derivation uses two properties, both valid in the thermodynamic limit.

- **(P1) Superadditivity.** $S(X+Y) \geq S(X)+S(Y)$. Two independent systems with variables X and Y are placed next to each other. Each pair of microstates, one from each system, is a microstate of the combined system with variables $X + Y$, and distinct pairs give distinct microstates. Hence $\Omega(X+Y) \geq \Omega(X)\Omega(Y)$, and (P1) follows from taking $k_B \ln$ of both sides.
- **(P2) Homogeneity.** $S(\lambda X) = \lambda S(X)$ for $\lambda > 0$. This property is extensivity. For identical particles, (P2) holds only if Ω counts the particles as indistinguishable, that is, with the factor $1/N!$ included.

Concavity of the entropy along the composition line. For $\lambda \in [0, 1]$, (P1) and (P2) give

$$S\big(\lambda X + (1-\lambda)Y\big) \;\geq\; S(\lambda X) + S\big((1-\lambda)Y\big) = \lambda S(X) + (1-\lambda)S(Y),$$

so S is concave in X:

$$\boxed{S\big(\lambda X + (1-\lambda)Y\big) \;\geq\; \lambda S(X) + (1-\lambda)S(Y).} \tag{5.25}$$

The total energy $2U$, the volume $2V$ and the total particle number $2N$ are now fixed. The only remaining variable is the composition, labeled by the number t of species-2 particles:

$$g(t) \equiv S(2U,\, 2V,\, 2N - t,\, t), \qquad t \in [0, 2N].$$

Table 2: Fixed variables and derivatives of the potential for each ensemble.

Ensemble	$\{N_i\}VS$	$\{N_i\}VT$	$\{N_i\}PS$	$\{\mu_i\}VT$	$\{N_i\}PT$
Conventional name	micro-canonical	canonical	isoenthalpic-isobaric	grand canonical	isothermal-isobaric
Thermodynamic potential	U	F	H	Φ	G
N_i	fixed	fixed	fixed	$-\dfrac{\partial\Phi}{\partial\mu_i}$	fixed
V	fixed	fixed	$\dfrac{\partial H}{\partial P}$	fixed	$\dfrac{\partial G}{\partial P}$
S	fixed	$-\dfrac{\partial F}{\partial T}$	fixed	$-\dfrac{\partial\Phi}{\partial T}$	$-\dfrac{\partial G}{\partial T}$
μ_i	$\dfrac{\partial U}{\partial N_i}$	$\dfrac{\partial F}{\partial N_i}$	$\dfrac{\partial H}{\partial N_i}$	fixed	$\dfrac{\partial G}{\partial N_i}$
P	$-\dfrac{\partial U}{\partial V}$	$-\dfrac{\partial F}{\partial V}$	fixed	$-\dfrac{\partial\Phi}{\partial V}$	fixed
T	$\dfrac{\partial U}{\partial S}$	fixed	$\dfrac{\partial H}{\partial S}$	fixed	fixed

The map $t \mapsto (2U, 2V, 2N - t, t)$ is affine, and a concave function composed with an affine map is concave, so g is concave. Three points on this line matter:

$$\begin{aligned} g(0) &= S(2U, 2V, 2N, 0) && \text{(all species 1)}, \\ g(2N) &= S(2U, 2V, 0, 2N) && \text{(all species 2)}, \\ g(N) &= S(2U, 2V, N, N) && \text{(half and half)}. \end{aligned}$$

Since $(N, N) = \frac{1}{2}(2N, 0) + \frac{1}{2}(0, 2N)$, the half-and-half state is the midpoint of the two pure states.

Entropy of mixing for distinguishable species. Before the partition is removed, the two systems are $X = (U, V, N, 0)$ and $Y = (U, V, 0, N)$, and the entropy of mixing is defined as

$$\boxed{\Delta S_{\text{mix}} \equiv S(2U, 2V, N, N) - S(U, V, N, 0) - S(U, V, 0, N) = g(N) - S(U, V, N, 0) - S(U, V, 0, N).} \tag{5.26}$$

Step 1: concavity at the midpoint. The concavity inequality along the line with $\lambda = \frac{1}{2}$ gives

$$g(N) \;\geq\; \tfrac{1}{2}\, g(0) + \tfrac{1}{2}\, g(2N).$$

The right side is the midpoint height of the chord that joins the two end points, so the graph of g does not lie below the chord.

Step 2: homogeneity at the end points. By (P2) with $\lambda = 2$,

$$g(0) = S(2U, 2V, 2N, 0) = 2\,S(U, V, N, 0), \qquad g(2N) = S(2U, 2V, 0, 2N) = 2\,S(U, V, 0, N).$$

With these values, the midpoint inequality becomes $g(N) \geq S(U, V, N, 0) + S(U, V, 0, N)$, that is,

$$\boxed{\Delta S_{\text{mix}} \geq 0.} \tag{5.27}$$

The same result follows directly from (P1), since $X + Y = (2U, 2V, N, N)$.

When equality holds. Equality in the midpoint inequality means that $g(N)$ lies on the chord. A concave function that touches the chord at an interior point equals the chord everywhere, because if some $g(t_0)$ were strictly above the chord, concavity would put $g(N)$ strictly above the chord too. Therefore

$$\boxed{\Delta S_{\text{mix}} = 0 \iff g \text{ is affine on } [0, 2N], \qquad \Delta S_{\text{mix}} > 0 \iff g \text{ is not affine.}} \tag{5.28}$$

In particular, $\Delta S_{\text{mix}} > 0$ whenever S is strictly concave along the composition line.

Identical particles and the paradox. For identical particles, $X = Y = (U, V, N)$, and (P2) gives

$$S(2U, 2V, 2N) = 2S(U, V, N) = S(X) + S(Y),$$

so $\Delta S_{\text{mix}} = 0$ exactly. In terms of g, if the two "species" are physically identical, S depends only on $N_1 + N_2$, so g is constant, hence affine, and the equality case applies. The difference between the two cases is whether the composition is a genuine variable of S. For distinguishable species, g is not affine, and the removal of the partition increases the entropy by the strictly positive amount ΔS_{mix}. For identical particles, g is constant and $\Delta S_{\text{mix}} = 0$. No continuity is expected between the two cases, because they differ in what the counting Ω treats as distinct. This difference is why (P2) holds for identical particles only with the $1/N!$ included.

5.7 Gibbs–Duhem Relation

The intensive variables are not independent. The Gibbs–Duhem relation states that the intensive variables $(T, P, \{\mu_i\})$ are not independent. The extensive variables are written as $x = (S, V, \{N_i\})$ and their conjugates as $\xi = (T, -P, \{\mu_i\})$, with ξ as in the Legendre transformation. Any thermodynamic potential f follows from U by exchanging the variables in a set A for their conjugates:

$$f = U - \sum_{a \in A} \xi_a x_a,$$

so that $f = U$ for $A = \varnothing$, $f = F$ for $A = \{S\}$, $f = G$ for $A = \{S, V\}$, and so on. Wherever f is differentiable in the natural variables,

$$df = \sum_{a \notin A} \xi_a\, dx_a - \sum_{a \in A} x_a\, d\xi_a.$$

By the Euler relation, $U = \sum_a \xi_a x_a$, so f is also

$$f = \sum_{a \notin A} \xi_a x_a, \qquad \text{hence} \qquad df = \sum_{a \notin A} \xi_a \, dx_a + \sum_{a \notin A} x_a \, d\xi_a.$$

The comparison of the two expressions for df gives

$$\boxed{\sum_a x_a \, d\xi_a = S \, dT - V \, dP + \sum_i N_i \, d\mu_i = 0.} \tag{5.29}$$

The result does not depend on the choice of A, so the relation holds in every ensemble. Of the n intensive variables, only $n - 1$ can be varied independently.

Why no ensemble fixes all the intensive variables. If all the extensive variables are exchanged for their conjugates, $A = \{S, V, \{N_i\}\}$, the potential becomes

$$f = U - TS + PV - \sum_i \mu_i N_i = 0.$$

This potential vanishes identically by the Euler relation. Such a potential would depend on no extensive variable at all, so nothing would fix the size of the system. A system that exchanges energy, volume and particles freely, with all of $(T, P, \{\mu_i\})$ held fixed, therefore has no ensemble of its own, and the Gibbs–Duhem relation states this fact.

Part II

Phase Transitions

6 First-Order Phase Transitions and Phase Diagrams

Phases and phase transitions. A phase of a system is a region of the space of natural variables in which the thermodynamic potential is analytic, that is, infinitely differentiable, with no kinks or divergences. A phase transition is a point where the potential fails to be analytic. Strictly, such singularities appear only in the thermodynamic limit $N \to \infty$, because the partition function of a finite system is analytic.

The Gibbs free energy and the composition variables. Phases are usually studied at fixed particle numbers, pressure and temperature for two reasons. Experimentally, these variables are easy to control. Structurally, the phases inside such a system exchange energy, volume and particles with each other, so $(\{\mu_i\}, P, T)$ are equal in all phases at equilibrium. The natural choice of potential is then the Gibbs free energy $G(T, P, \{N_i\})$. Because G is extensive,

$$G(T, P, \{N_i\}) = N\, g(T, P, \{x_i\}), \qquad x_i = N_i/N,$$

so the total size N does not affect the analyticity of G, and only g matters. Of the C mole fractions $\{x_i\}$ of a C-component system, only $C-1$ are independent, because $\sum_i x_i = 1$. A phase is therefore a region of the intensive variables $(T, P, \{x_i\})$, which span a $(C-1)+2 = (C+1)$-dimensional space. The collection of all phases in this space is the phase diagram.

First-order transitions as creases of g. At equilibrium, g is continuous, so a phase transition is never a jump in the potential itself. With g as one more axis on the $(C+1)$-dimensional space $(T, P, \{x_i\})$, the potential forms a hypersurface $g(T, P, \{x_i\})$. A first-order transition is a crease (kink) of this hypersurface, across which g is continuous but the first derivatives of g jump:

$$s = -\frac{\partial g}{\partial T}, \qquad v = \frac{\partial g}{\partial P},$$

which are the entropy and the volume per particle. Equivalently, $S = -\partial G/\partial T$ and $V = \partial G/\partial P$ are discontinuous, which gives a latent heat $L = T\Delta S$ and a volume change ΔV. Melting and boiling are examples. On the transition locus, the coexisting phases share the same $(\{\mu_i\}, P, T)$ but differ in s, v and composition. For this reason, the transition appears as the boundary of a coexistence region in the phase diagram.

Higher-order transitions. Higher-order transitions also exist. The order of a transition is the order of the lowest derivative of g that is discontinuous or singular. For higher-order transitions, the hypersurface has no kink, and the singularity appears in the curvature. These transitions include the continuous transitions, such as the ferromagnetic Curie point, where response functions such as the heat capacity diverge. A later section treats these transitions.

6.1 Gibbs Phase Rule

Counting the degrees of freedom. Suppose $\mathcal{P}$ phases of a system with C components coexist. At equilibrium, all the phases share the same $C+2$ intensive variables $(T, P, \mu_1, \ldots, \mu_C)$. Each

phase has its own Gibbs–Duhem relation,

$$S_\alpha\, dT - V_\alpha\, dP + \sum_i N_{i,\alpha}\, d\mu_i = 0, \qquad \alpha = 1, \ldots, \mathcal{P},$$

which imposes $\mathcal{P}$ independent constraints on these variables. The number of degrees of freedom F is the number of variables minus the number of constraints,

$$\boxed{F + \mathcal{P} = C + 2.} \tag{6.1}$$

This relation is the Gibbs phase rule. The rule counts only intensive degrees of freedom, so the amount of each phase remains free and is not counted.

Limits of the phase rule. The rule in this form applies only if $(T, P, \mu_1, \ldots, \mu_C)$ are the only intensive variables. Magnetic systems, for example, also depend on the magnetic field $\vec{B}$, which adds another intensive variable to the count.

6.2 Clapeyron Equation and Fixed-Composition (P–T) Phase Diagram

The two-phase coexistence curve. Temperature and pressure appear in every phase diagram, whatever the number of components. The P–T plane at fixed composition $\{x_i\}$ is a two-dimensional slice of the $(C+1)$-dimensional phase diagram. Only P and T vary in this slice, so the slice has two degrees of freedom. Two phases, 1 and 2, coexist when every chemical potential matches,

$$\mu_i^{(1)}(T, P) = \mu_i^{(2)}(T, P), \qquad i = 1, \ldots, C.$$

These conditions relate P and T and reduce the degrees of freedom from two to one. The coexistence locus is therefore a curve in the plane.

The Clapeyron equation. Along this curve, the two phases keep equal chemical potentials, so $d\mu_i^{(1)} = d\mu_i^{(2)}$, and the Gibbs–Duhem relation at fixed composition gives

$$-s_1\, dT + v_1\, dP = -s_2\, dT + v_2\, dP,$$

which is the Clapeyron equation

$$\boxed{\frac{dP}{dT} = \frac{\Delta s}{\Delta v}}, \qquad \Delta s = s_2 - s_1, \quad \Delta v = v_2 - v_1. \tag{6.2}$$

At coexistence, the transition proceeds reversibly at fixed T and P, so the latent heat per particle is $\ell = T\Delta s$, and

$$\boxed{\frac{dP}{dT} = \frac{\ell}{T\,\Delta v}.} \tag{6.3}$$

Three-phase coexistence and the triple point. If a third phase, 3, also coexists, then

$$\mu_i^{(1)}(T,P) = \mu_i^{(2)}(T,P) = \mu_i^{(3)}(T,P), \qquad i = 1,\dots,C.$$

Each pair of phases has its own coexistence curve, $\mu^{(1)} = \mu^{(2)}$, $\mu^{(2)} = \mu^{(3)}$ and $\mu^{(1)} = \mu^{(3)}$. A point on the first two curves satisfies $\mu^{(1)} = \mu^{(2)} = \mu^{(3)}$, so the point lies on the third curve as well, and only two of the three conditions are independent. Two independent equations in the two unknowns (T, P) leave no degrees of freedom, so three phases can coexist only at an isolated point, the triple point, where the three two-phase curves intersect.

6.3 Unary System

Definition and phase rule. A unary system has only one component, $C = 1$, and is a special case of the fixed-composition slice with $x = 1$. The unary system is the building block of higher-dimensional phase diagrams and introduces the terminology used for them. For $C = 1$, the phase rule reads $F = 3 - \mathcal{P}$, so the number of coexisting phases $\mathcal{P}$ fixes the number of free variables.

Bivariant, univariant and invariant equilibria. Within a single phase ($\mathcal{P} = 1$, $F = 2$), P and T vary freely, and the system is in bivariant equilibrium. When two phases coexist ($\mathcal{P} = 2$, $F = 1$), only one of P and T varies freely, and the coexistence curve $P(T)$, with the slope given by the Clapeyron equation, fixes the other. The system is then in univariant equilibrium, and the two-phase coexistence locus is a univariant curve. When three phases coexist ($\mathcal{P} = 3$, $F = 0$), no variable varies freely. The system is in invariant equilibrium, and the point of three-phase coexistence is an invariant point, the triple point.

The chemical potential of each phase. For $C = 1$, the Euler relation gives $G = \mu N$, so the Gibbs free energy per particle is the chemical potential, $g = \mu$. Each phase α has a separate function $\mu_\alpha(T, P)$, defined wherever the phase exists at least as a local minimum of G. The Gibbs–Duhem relation per particle, $d\mu = -s\,dT + v\,dP$, gives the slopes

$$\boxed{\left.\frac{\partial \mu_\alpha}{\partial T}\right|_P = -s_\alpha < 0, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial \mu_\alpha}{\partial P}\right|_T = v_\alpha > 0.} \tag{6.4}$$

At fixed P, every curve $\mu_\alpha(T)$ therefore decreases with temperature, and the curve of the phase with the larger entropy decreases faster. With the heat capacity per particle at constant pressure, $c_P \equiv T\,\partial s/\partial T|_P > 0$, the curvature $\partial^2\mu_\alpha/\partial T^2|_P = -c_P/T$ is negative, so each curve is also concave. In most substances, $s_{\text{vapor}} > s_{\text{liquid}} > s_{\text{solid}}$, so the solid has the lowest μ at low temperature, the liquid at intermediate temperature and the vapor at high temperature (Fig. 2).

The stable phase minimizes the chemical potential. The Gibbs free energy $G = N\mu$ is minimized at fixed (N, P, T). The stable phase is therefore the phase with the lowest chemical potential, and the equilibrium chemical potential is the lower envelope of the single-phase curves:

$$\boxed{\mu(T,P) = \min_\alpha \mu_\alpha(T,P).} \tag{6.5}$$

Two curves cross at a transition temperature, such as the melting temperature T_m or the boiling temperature T_b. At the crossing, the envelope is continuous, but the slope jumps from $-s_1$ to $-s_2$. This kink is the crease of g in a one-dimensional slice, and the jump in slope gives the latent heat per particle, $\ell = T\Delta s$.

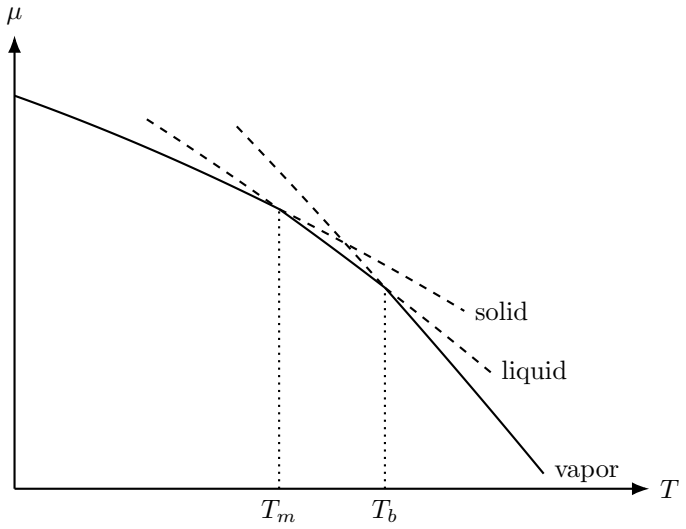


Figure 2: Chemical potentials of the solid, liquid and vapor phases at fixed pressure. Solid lines: stable branches (lower envelope). Dashed lines: metastable branches.

Metastable phases and polymorphs. Beyond a crossing, the curve of the former phase continues above the envelope (dashed lines in Fig. 2). A phase on such a branch is metastable, because G is at a local but not a global minimum. The phase persists until a fluctuation nucleates the stable phase. A supercooled liquid below T_m and a superheated liquid above T_b are examples. A unary system may also have several solid phases with different crystal structures, called polymorphs, each with a separate curve $\mu_\alpha(T, P)$. For example, the black γ phase of $CsPbI_3$ is a metastable polymorph at room temperature, with the yellow δ phase as the stable phase.

Slopes of the coexistence curves. The Clapeyron equation fixes the slope of each univariant curve in the P–T diagram (Fig. 3). Melting involves a small volume change, so the solid–liquid curve is steep. For most substances, $\Delta v > 0$ on melting, and the slope is positive. Water is an exception, because ice is less dense than liquid water, so $\Delta v < 0$ and the melting curve has a negative slope. On the liquid–vapor and solid–vapor curves, the vapor volume dominates, $\Delta v \approx v_{\text{vapor}}$. If the vapor behaves as an ideal gas, $Pv = k_B T$, and the Clapeyron equation becomes the Clausius–Clapeyron equation

$$\boxed{\frac{dP}{dT} = \frac{\ell P}{k_B T^2}.} \tag{6.6}$$

For a constant latent heat, integration from a reference point (T_0, P_0) on the curve gives

$$\boxed{P(T) = P_0 \exp\left[-\frac{\ell}{k_B}\left(\frac{1}{T} - \frac{1}{T_0}\right)\right].} \tag{6.7}$$

The vapor pressure therefore rises exponentially with temperature. At the triple point, the entropy changes around a closed cycle of the three phases sum to zero, so the latent heats satisfy $\ell_{\text{sub}} = \ell_{\text{fus}} + \ell_{\text{vap}}$. Since $\ell_{\text{sub}} > \ell_{\text{vap}}$ and Δv is nearly the same for both, the solid–vapor curve is steeper than the liquid–vapor curve at the triple point.

The critical point. The liquid–vapor curve does not continue indefinitely. As T rises along the curve, the liquid expands and the vapor compresses until Δv and Δs both vanish at the critical point (T_c, P_c), where the curve ends. Above T_c, liquid and vapor can no longer be distinguished, and the fluid is called supercritical. A path that circles around the critical point connects the liquid to the vapor without crossing any coexistence curve, so the potential stays analytic along the whole path. By the definition of a phase, liquid and vapor are therefore one fluid phase, and the distinction between them exists only below T_c. No such path exists between solid and liquid, because the two phases differ in symmetry, and a symmetry cannot change continuously. The solid–liquid curve therefore has no critical point. The critical point itself is a continuous transition and is treated later.

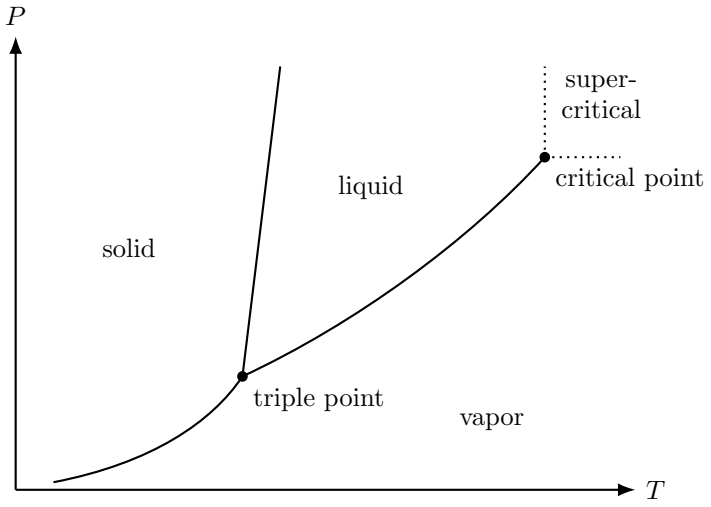


Figure 3: Schematic P–T diagram of a unary system with a triple point and a liquid–vapor critical point.

Two-phase coexistence in the P–v plane. From here on, $v \equiv V/N$ and $f \equiv F/N$ denote the volume and the Helmholtz free energy per particle, $n_\alpha \equiv N_\alpha/N$ denotes the fraction of particles in phase α, and the subscripts l and g label the liquid and the vapor (gas). The P–T diagram does not show the amount of each phase. An isotherm in the P–v plane below T_c does. As the vapor is compressed, the pressure rises until the vapor pressure $P_{\text{sat}}(T)$ is reached at $v = v_g$. Further compression converts vapor into liquid at constant pressure until $v = v_l$, and only then is the liquid compressed. Between v_l and v_g, the system is a mixture of liquid and vapor at the same (T, P_{sat}). The phase rule allows exactly this mixture, because coexistence fixes P at fixed T but leaves the amounts of the two phases free.

The lever rule. Particle number and volume are conserved:

$$n_l + n_g = 1, \qquad n_l v_l + n_g v_g = v.$$

These two equations give the lever rule

$$\boxed{n_l = \frac{v_g - v}{v_g - v_l}, \qquad n_g = \frac{v - v_l}{v_g - v_l}.} \tag{6.8}$$

Equivalently, $n_l\,(v - v_l) = n_g\,(v_g - v)$. The overall state v is the fulcrum of a lever with arms $v - v_l$ and $v_g - v$, and each phase fraction is proportional to the arm on the opposite side. The overall state therefore lies closer to the dominant phase. The rule holds for any conserved extensive quantity per particle, and the binary system applies the same rule to the composition.

The common tangent construction. The free energy per particle at fixed T gives the coexisting volumes v_l and v_g. A phase at (T, v) has the pressure $P = -\partial f/\partial v$ and, by the Euler relation $F = -PV + \mu N$, the chemical potential $\mu = f + Pv$. The tangent line to f at v therefore has slope $-P$ and intercept μ at $v = 0$, which is the Legendre construction of Section 4 again. Coexistence requires equal pressures and equal chemical potentials. Equal pressures give equal slopes, and equal chemical potentials give $f_g(v_g) - f_l(v_l) = -P_{\text{sat}}(v_g - v_l)$, so the chord between the two points has the same slope as the tangents:

$$\boxed{f_l'(v_l) = f_g'(v_g) = \frac{f_g(v_g) - f_l(v_l)}{v_g - v_l} = -P_{\text{sat}}.} \tag{6.9}$$

The two tangent lines therefore coincide in a common tangent (Fig. 4).

The mixture lies on the tangent and minimizes F. For $v_l < v < v_g$, the mixture has the free energy per particle

$$f_{\text{mix}}(v) = n_l\, f_l(v_l) + n_g\, f_g(v_g).$$

By the lever rule, n_l and n_g are linear in v, so f_{mix} is the straight segment between the two tangent points, that is, the common tangent. Where the single-phase curve lies above this segment, the mixture has the lower free energy, and the minimization of F at fixed (N, V, T) selects the mixture. The equilibrium $f(v)$ is therefore the convex hull of the single-phase curves, the largest convex function that lies below all of them. This construction restores the convexity of F in V that stability requires and explains why the pressure, $-\partial f/\partial v$, stays constant across the two-phase region.

Maxwell's equal-area rule. A model equation of state, such as that of van der Waals, may give a single isotherm $P(v)$ with a non-monotonic loop below T_c. The common tangent then becomes a condition on $P(v)$. The integral of $P = -\partial f/\partial v$ along the model isotherm gives $f(v_l) - f(v_g) = \int_{v_l}^{v_g} P\,dv$, and the common tangent gives $f(v_l) - f(v_g) = P_{\text{sat}}(v_g - v_l)$. Hence

$$\boxed{\int_{v_l}^{v_g} P(v)\,dv = P_{\text{sat}}\,(v_g - v_l).} \tag{6.10}$$

The horizontal line $P = P_{\text{sat}}$ therefore cuts the loop into two regions of equal area.

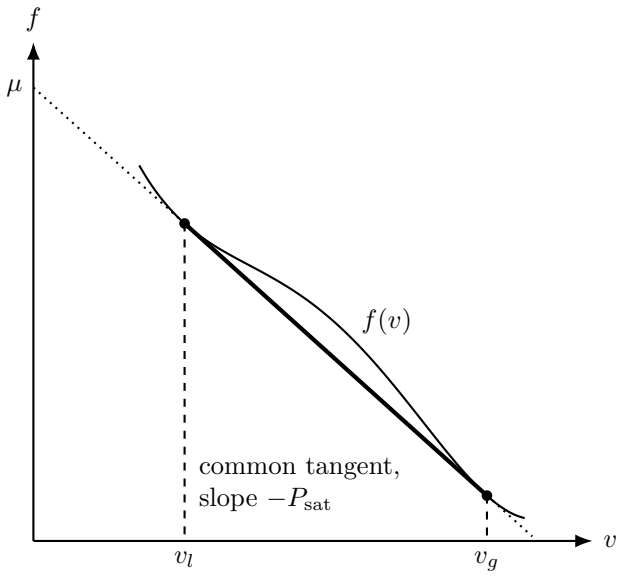


Figure 4: Common tangent construction on the free energy per particle at fixed $T < T_c$. Thick line: equilibrium two-phase mixture (convex hull).

Outlook to the binary system. The binary system uses both tools with the composition x in place of v. A tie line joins the two coexisting phases, the lever rule gives the phase fractions along it, and the common tangent of $g(x)$ at fixed (T, P) gives the compositions of the coexisting phases.

7 Binary System

7.1 The X–P–T Diagram

Composition variable and phase rule. A binary system has two components, $C = 2$, so one independent variable, $X = x_2$ with $x_1 = 1 - X$, describes the composition. The phase diagram is therefore three-dimensional in (P, T, X). The diagram can be pictured as a stack of fixed-composition P–T diagrams, one for each value of X. The phase rule reads $F = 4 - \mathcal{P}$, so each unary structure gains one dimension:

- Tervariant volume ($\mathcal{P} = 1$, $F = 3$). The bivariant regions of the unary diagram become volumes in which P, T and X all vary freely without a phase change. The cross section of each volume changes with X.
- Bivariant surface ($\mathcal{P} = 2$, $F = 2$). The univariant curves become surfaces. Two coexisting phases generally have different compositions, so each phase has its own bivariant surface, and tie lines join the two surfaces. The region between the surfaces is the two-phase region, in which the overall composition fixes the amount of each phase.
- Univariant curve ($\mathcal{P} = 3$, $F = 1$). The invariant points become curves, along which only one variable varies freely. Three bivariant surfaces, one for each pair of phases, meet along each such curve.
- Invariant point ($\mathcal{P} = 4$, $F = 0$). A new kind of invariant point appears, at which none of P, T or X varies. Every subset of the four phases coexists near this point, so $\binom{4}{3} = 4$ univariant curves, $\binom{4}{2} = 6$ two-phase (bivariant) surfaces and $\binom{4}{1} = 4$ single-phase (tervariant) volumes meet there. This point is therefore also called the quadruple point.

7.2 Gibbs Free Energy of a Binary Solution

The Gibbs free energy as a sum over the components. From here on, $\mu_i^{\circ,\alpha}(T, P)$ denotes the chemical potential of pure component i in the structure of phase α, and $g^\alpha(T, P, X) \equiv G^\alpha/N$ denotes the Gibbs free energy per particle of phase α, with $N = N_1 + N_2$. The superscript α is dropped when only one phase is discussed. The composition dependence of g decides which phases coexist in a binary system. By the Euler relation of the multi-component system, the Gibbs free energy of a phase is the sum of the contributions of the two components:

$$\boxed{G = N_1\mu_1 + N_2\mu_2, \qquad g(T, P, X) = (1 - X)\,\mu_1 + X\,\mu_2,} \tag{7.1}$$

where each μ_i depends on (T, P, X). This relation holds for any solution and requires no model of the interactions. The tangent intercepts, the common tangent and the lever rule below follow from it alone.

7.3 Chemical Potentials as Tangent Intercepts

Chemical potentials from $g(X)$. The Gibbs free energy of a phase is $G = N\,g(T,P,X)$ with $X = N_2/N$. At fixed (T,P), the derivatives $\partial X/\partial N_2|_{N_1} = (1-X)/N$ and $\partial X/\partial N_1|_{N_2} = -X/N$ give

$$\mu_2 = \left.\frac{\partial G}{\partial N_2}\right|_{T,P,N_1} = g + N\frac{\partial g}{\partial X}\,\frac{1-X}{N}, \qquad \mu_1 = \left.\frac{\partial G}{\partial N_1}\right|_{T,P,N_2} = g - N\frac{\partial g}{\partial X}\,\frac{X}{N},$$

that is,

$$\boxed{\mu_1 = g - X\,\frac{\partial g}{\partial X}, \qquad \mu_2 = g + (1-X)\,\frac{\partial g}{\partial X}.} \tag{7.2}$$

The tangent line to g at X therefore meets the axis $X=0$ at μ_1 and the axis $X=1$ at μ_2. This construction is the Legendre construction of the unary system with two intercepts instead of one. Substitution of Eq. (7.2) into Eq. (7.1) returns g, as required.

7.4 Solution Models

The ideal solution. Explicit phase diagrams require the composition dependence of each μ_i. The simplest assumption is that the two components just mix. An ideal solution is defined by

$$\boxed{\mu_i(T,P,X) = \mu_i^{\circ}(T,P) + k_B T \ln x_i, \qquad x_1 = 1-X, \quad x_2 = X.} \tag{7.3}$$

Each component then lowers its chemical potential below the pure value by $k_B T \ln x_i$. Equation (7.1) gives the Gibbs free energy per particle

$$\boxed{g_{\mathrm{id}}(T,P,X) = (1-X)\,\mu_1^{\circ} + X\,\mu_2^{\circ} + k_B T\big[X\ln X + (1-X)\ln(1-X)\big].} \tag{7.4}$$

The regular solution. Here, w denotes the interaction parameter per particle. The regular solution adds to the ideal solution the simplest term that vanishes for both pure components and is symmetric in the composition:

$$\boxed{g_{\mathrm{reg}}(T,P,X) = g_{\mathrm{id}}(T,P,X) + w\,X(1-X).} \tag{7.5}$$

The model favors unlike neighbors for $w<0$ and like neighbors for $w>0$. Section 7.9 shows that $w>0$ can split one solution into two.

7.5 Two-Phase Equilibrium: Common Tangent and Lever Rule

Equal chemical potentials as a common tangent. Two phases, α and β, at the same (T,P) have separate curves $g^{\alpha}(X)$ and $g^{\beta}(X)$. The phases coexist with compositions X^{α} and X^{β} when both chemical potentials match, $\mu_1^{\alpha} = \mu_1^{\beta}$ and $\mu_2^{\alpha} = \mu_2^{\beta}$. By Eq. (7.2), the tangent lines at X^{α} and X^{β} then have the same intercepts at $X=0$ and at $X=1$, so the two lines coincide:

$$\boxed{g^{\alpha\prime}(X^{\alpha}) = g^{\beta\prime}(X^{\beta}) = \frac{g^{\beta}(X^{\beta}) - g^{\alpha}(X^{\alpha})}{X^{\beta} - X^{\alpha}}.} \tag{7.6}$$

This condition is the common tangent construction (Fig. 5). The unary construction on $f(v)$ needed one intercept, because the unary system has one chemical potential. The binary construction fixes two intercepts, one for each component.

The equilibrium g is the convex hull. At fixed (T, P, N_1, N_2), the system minimizes G. An overall composition X between X^α and X^β can split into the two phases, and the free energy of this mixture lies on the straight segment of the common tangent. Where both single-phase curves lie above the segment, the two-phase mixture is stable. The equilibrium $g(X)$ is therefore the convex hull of all the single-phase curves. A composition on a curved part of the hull is a single phase, and a composition on a straight part splits into the two phases at the ends of the segment. The phase rule agrees, because at fixed (T, P), $F = 4 - \mathcal{P} - 2 = 0$ for two phases, so the compositions X^α and X^β are fixed.

The lever rule on a tie line. Here, $n_\alpha \equiv N^\alpha/N$ denotes the fraction of all particles in phase α, with $N^\alpha = N_1^\alpha + N_2^\alpha$. In a phase diagram, the segment between X^α and X^β at fixed (T, P) is a tie line. Conservation of the particle number and of component 2 gives

$$n_\alpha + n_\beta = 1, \qquad n_\alpha X^\alpha + n_\beta X^\beta = X,$$

and hence the lever rule

$$\boxed{n_\alpha = \frac{X^\beta - X}{X^\beta - X^\alpha}, \qquad n_\beta = \frac{X - X^\alpha}{X^\beta - X^\alpha}.} \tag{7.7}$$

The rule is the unary lever rule with the composition X in place of the volume v.

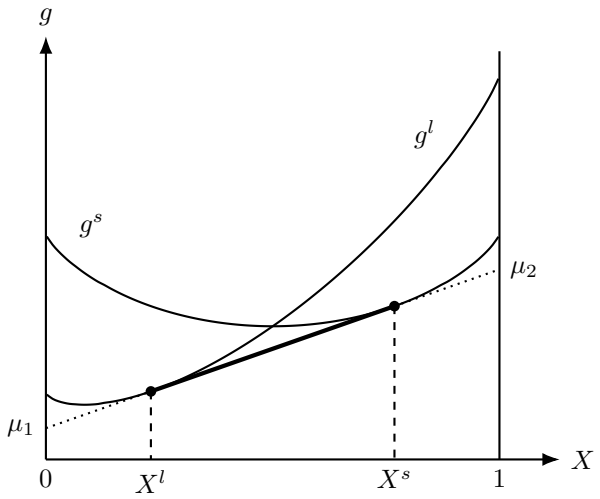


Figure 5: Common tangent construction for a solid (s) and a liquid (l) solution at fixed (T, P). Thick line: two-phase mixture on the convex hull. Intercepts: the common chemical potentials μ_1 and μ_2.

7.6 Isobaric T–X Diagram of an Isomorphous System

Isomorphous systems and the phase rule at fixed pressure. Two components are isomorphous when they dissolve completely in each other in both the liquid and the solid. This behavior requires the same crystal structure and similar atomic sizes, as in Cu–Ni, Si–Ge and Ag–Au. Most experiments on condensed phases run at a fixed pressure, so the phase diagram is the T–X slice of the X–P–T diagram. With P fixed, the phase rule becomes

$$\boxed{F = C + 1 - \mathcal{P} = 3 - \mathcal{P}.} \tag{7.8}$$

A single phase fills an area ($F = 2$), and two coexisting phases at a chosen T have fixed compositions ($F = 1$), which form a tie line.

Coexistence of ideal solid and liquid solutions. If both the solid and the liquid are ideal solutions, Eq. (7.3) turns the equilibrium condition $\mu_i^s = \mu_i^l$ into

$$\mu_i^{\circ,s} + k_B T \ln x_i^s = \mu_i^{\circ,l} + k_B T \ln x_i^l, \qquad \text{so} \qquad \frac{x_i^s}{x_i^l} = \exp\left(\frac{\mu_i^{\circ,l} - \mu_i^{\circ,s}}{k_B T}\right).$$

Pure component i melts at T_i with the latent heat per particle ℓ_i. For a constant ℓ_i, the entropy of fusion is ℓ_i/T_i, so $\mu_i^{\circ,l} - \mu_i^{\circ,s} = \ell_i(1 - T/T_i)$, and

$$\boxed{k_i(T) \equiv \frac{x_i^s}{x_i^l} = \exp\left[\frac{\ell_i}{k_B}\left(\frac{1}{T} - \frac{1}{T_i}\right)\right].} \tag{7.9}$$

The two conditions $x_1^s + x_2^s = 1$ and $x_1^l + x_2^l = 1$ then give $k_1(1 - X^l) + k_2 X^l = 1$, and therefore

$$\boxed{X^l(T) = \frac{1 - k_1}{k_2 - k_1}, \qquad X^s(T) = k_2\, X^l(T).} \tag{7.10}$$

The liquidus, the solidus and the lens. The curve $X^l(T)$ is the liquidus, above which the system is fully liquid. The curve $X^s(T)$ is the solidus, below which the system is fully solid. At $T = T_1$, $k_1 = 1$, and both curves reach $X = 0$. At $T = T_2$, $k_2 = 1$, and both reach $X = 1$. Between the two melting points, the curves enclose a lens-shaped two-phase region (Fig. 6). For $T_1 < T < T_2$, $k_2 > 1$, so $X^s > X^l$, and the solid is richer than the liquid in the component with the higher melting point.

Equilibrium cooling through the lens. A liquid of overall composition X_0 starts to solidify at the liquidus temperature T_L, where the first solid has the composition $X^s(T_L) > X_0$. On further cooling, the liquid composition follows the liquidus, the solid composition follows the solidus, and the lever rule gives the amount of each phase on the tie line at every temperature. The last liquid disappears at the solidus temperature T_S, where the solid composition reaches X_0. A binary alloy therefore melts over the range $T_S < T < T_L$ instead of at a single temperature. At fixed X_0, the latent heat is released gradually over this range, so the entropy has no jump. Only the heat capacity jumps, at T_L and at T_S, unlike the single crease of a unary transition.

Non-equilibrium solidification. Equilibrium cooling requires the solid to change its composition along the solidus. Diffusion in a solid is slow, so in practice the first solid keeps its high content of component 2. The grains then have a composition gradient, called coring, and the remaining liquid becomes richer in component 1 than the diagram predicts. Zone refining uses the same separation to purify silicon, because each pass of a molten zone pushes the impurity into the liquid.

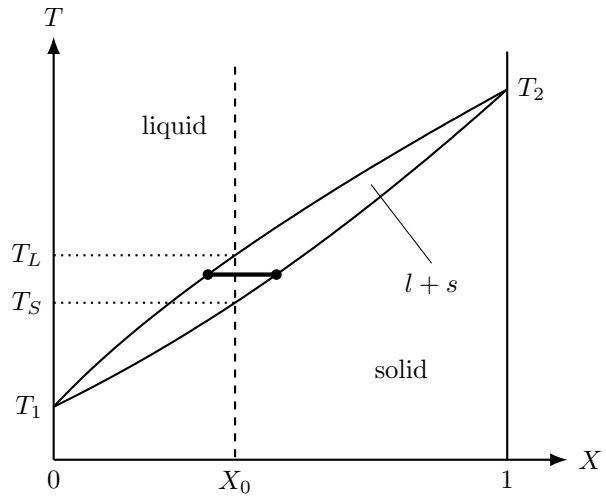


Figure 6: Isobaric T–X diagram of an isomorphous system with ideal solid and liquid solutions. Upper curve: liquidus. Lower curve: solidus. Thick line: tie line at one temperature during cooling of the composition X_0.

7.7 Isothermal P–X Diagram of a Liquid–Vapor System

Raoult's law. Here, P_i denotes the partial pressure of component i in the vapor, $P_i^*(T)$ the vapor pressure of pure liquid i, and X^l and X^g the compositions of the liquid and the vapor. An ideal gas mixture has $\mu_i^g = \mu_i^{\circ,g}(T) + k_B T \ln P_i$, with $P_i = x_i^g P$. For the pure liquid in equilibrium with its vapor, $\mu_i^{\circ,l} = \mu_i^{\circ,g}(T) + k_B T \ln P_i^*$, where the weak pressure dependence of the liquid is neglected. An ideal liquid solution has $\mu_i^l = \mu_i^{\circ,l} + k_B T \ln x_i^l$, and the equality $\mu_i^l = \mu_i^g$ gives Raoult's law:

$$\boxed{P_i = x_i^l \, P_i^*.} \tag{7.11}$$

The bubble curve and the dew curve. The total pressure is the sum of the partial pressures,

$$\boxed{P = (1 - X^l)\, P_1^* + X^l \, P_2^*,} \tag{7.12}$$

which is linear in X^l. This line is the bubble curve, where a compressed liquid forms the first bubble of vapor on decompression. The vapor composition follows from $X^g = P_2/P = X^l P_2^*/P$. Elimination of X^l with $1 - X^l = (1 - X^g)P/P_1^*$ and $X^l = X^g P/P_2^*$ gives the dew curve

$$\boxed{P = \left[\frac{1 - X^g}{P_1^*} + \frac{X^g}{P_2^*} \right]^{-1},} \tag{7.13}$$

where the first drop of liquid forms on compression. The liquid is stable above the bubble curve, the vapor below the dew curve, and the two phases coexist between them (Fig. 7). The vapor is always richer in the more volatile component, the component with the larger P_i^*. The tie lines are horizontal, and the lever rule applies along them. The isobaric T–X diagram of the same system is the lens turned upside down, because the liquid is stable at low T but at high P.

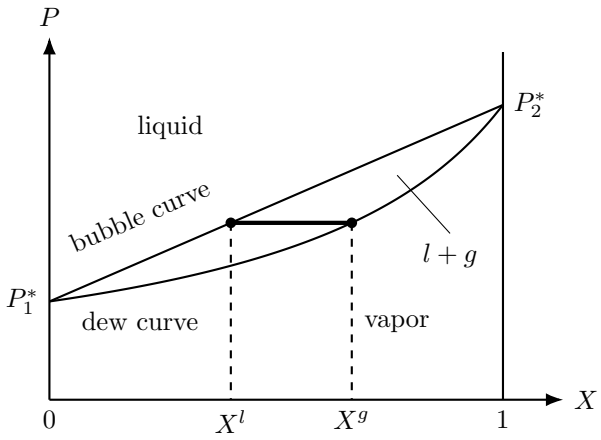


Figure 7: Isothermal P–X diagram of an ideal liquid–vapor system ($P_2^* = 3P_1^*$). Upper line: bubble curve. Lower curve: dew curve. Thick line: tie line.

7.8 The P–T Projection

Projecting the X–P–T diagram. A projection of the X–P–T diagram along X collects every composition in one P–T plane. The vapor-pressure curves of the two pure components appear at $X = 0$ and $X = 1$, each ending at the critical point of that component. A slice at fixed overall composition, an isopleth, gives a loop between these two curves, with the bubble curve on the high-pressure side and the dew curve on the low-pressure side (Fig. 8). The loop closes at the critical point of the mixture, and the critical points of all compositions form the critical locus that joins the two pure critical points. The univariant three-phase equilibria of the X–P–T diagram project to curves, and the quadruple points project to points. The projection therefore shows at a glance which temperatures and pressures allow more than one phase for some composition.

7.9 Beyond the Ideal Solution: Miscibility Gap

Spinodal and critical temperature. For $w > 0$, the regular solution favors like pairs, and at low temperature the curve $g_{\text{reg}}(X)$ becomes concave in a central range of compositions. Inside this range, a homogeneous solution is unstable against small composition fluctuations. The boundary is the spinodal, where the curvature vanishes:

$$\frac{\partial^2 g_{\text{reg}}}{\partial X^2} = \frac{k_B T}{X(1-X)} - 2w = 0.$$

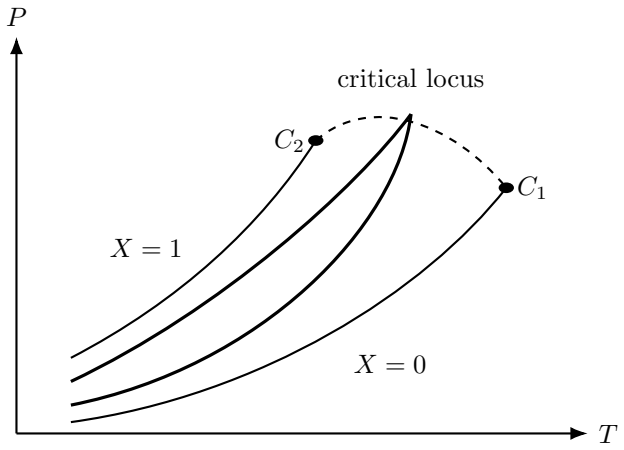


Figure 8: Schematic P–T projection of a binary liquid–vapor system. Thin lines: vapor-pressure curves of the pure components, ending at the critical points C_1 and C_2. Thick loop: isopleth at one composition. Dashed curve: critical locus.

Hence

$$\boxed{T_{\mathrm{sp}}(X) = \frac{2w}{k_B}\,X(1-X), \qquad T_c = \frac{w}{2k_B}.} \tag{7.14}$$

The spinodal reaches its maximum, the critical temperature T_c, at $X = 1/2$. Above T_c, the components mix at every composition.

The binodal from the common tangent. Below T_c, the convex hull of the single curve $g_{\mathrm{reg}}(X)$ has a common tangent that touches the curve at two compositions, and the solution splits into two solutions with the same structure. The linear terms of g do not affect the tangent points, and the remaining curve is symmetric about $X = 1/2$, so the common tangent is horizontal after the linear terms are removed. The tangent points therefore satisfy $k_BT\ln[X/(1-X)] + w(1-2X) = 0$, which gives the binodal

$$\boxed{T_{\mathrm{b}}(X) = \frac{w}{k_B}\,\frac{1-2X}{\ln[(1-X)/X]}.} \tag{7.15}$$

The region under the binodal is the miscibility gap (Fig. 9). Between the binodal and the spinodal, a homogeneous solution is metastable, as a supercooled liquid is in the unary system. Inside the spinodal, the solution is unstable and separates spontaneously.

Toward eutectic and peritectic systems. A miscibility gap in the solid that meets the melting lens, or components with different crystal structures, produce a three-phase equilibrium at fixed pressure. By the phase rule at fixed P, three phases coexist at a single temperature, the eutectic or peritectic temperature, where a liquid transforms into two solids or a liquid and a solid transform into another solid. Non-ideal solid and liquid solutions can also make the liquidus and the solidus touch at a minimum or a maximum, where the two phases have the same composition and the alloy melts congruently, as a pure substance does. These systems are the subject of the next section.

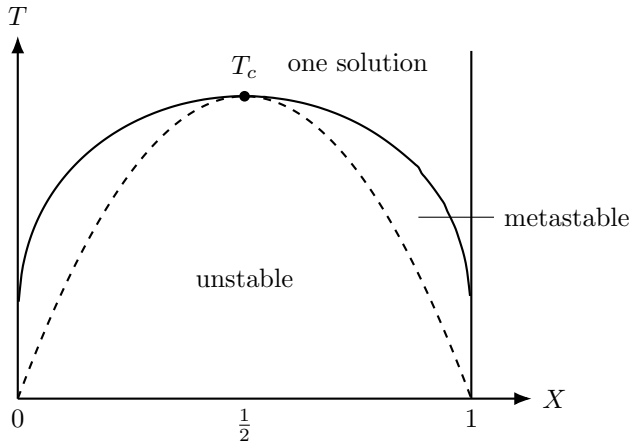


Figure 9: Miscibility gap of a regular solution. Solid curve: binodal (coexistence). Dashed curve: spinodal (limit of metastability).

Part III

Classical Thermodynamics

Part IV

Physical Chemistry

Part V

Quantum Statistical Mechanics